THE FINAL VERDICT

Ian Morris

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Hell is terrifying.

About the subject of Hell, Spurgeon once preached:

> When thou diest thy soul will be tormented alone—that will be a hell for it—but at the day of judgment thy body will join thy soul, and then thou wilt have twin hells, body and soul shall be together, each brimfull of pain, thy soul sweating in its inmost pore drops of blood, and thy body from head to foot suffused with agony; conscience, judgment, memory, all tortured, but more—thy head tormented with racking pains, thine eyes starting from their sockets with sights of blood and woe; thine ears tormented with "Sullen moans and hollow groans. And shrieks of tortured ghosts." Thine heart beating high with fever; thy pulse rattling at an enormous rate in agony; thy limbs crackling like the martyrs in the fire, and yet unburnt; thyself, put in a vessel of hot oil, pained, yet coming out undestroyed; all thy veins becoming a road for the hot feet of pain to travel on; every nerve a string on which the devil shall ever play his diabolical tune of Hell's Unutterable Lament; thy soul for ever and ever aching, and thy body palpitating in unison with thy soul.[1]

Many centuries earlier, Dante wrote his classic epic, *The Divine Comedy,* featuring a pilgrim's journey through Hell. His characters meet ever-parched sinners fused into hot rocks, boiled in blood, and tormented by demons.[2] On the gates of Hell are written the words, "'Through me you pass into the city of woe: Through me you pass into eternal pain: Through me among the people lost for aye. Justice the founder of my fabric moved : To rear me was the task of power divine, Supremest wisdom, and primeval love…All hope abandon, ye who enter here."[3]

Hell is not terrifying without a reason. Justice must be enacted; God must punish sin according to His character. He provides grace and mercy to escape this wrath, but He cannot save those who reject his provision. They *must* burn.

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[1] C.H. Spurgeon, "The Resurrection of the Dead" (A sermon, New Park Street Chapel, Southwark, Delivered on Sabbath Morning, February 17, 1856), accessed March 3, 2024 at https://ccel.org/ccel/spurgeon/sermons02/sermons02.xiii.html

[2] Dante Alighieri, *Dante's Inferno*, trans. Henry Francis Gary (New York : Cassell, Petter, Galpin & Co., 1866), 98-103, 60-65, 115-119.

[3] Dante Alighieri, *Dante's Inferno*, 12.

To the onlooking world, Hell seems inexplicably cruel and unreasonable. How could a good God torture humans for all eternity? It seems paradoxical. Many turn away from the faith in perplexion, convinced the Christian God 'makes no sense' or, worse, 'is a monster.'

C.S. Lewis once wrote, "There is no doctrine which I would more willingly remove from Christianity."[4] Yet, of course, Hell cannot be denied. The Bible teaches it, and behind that is the support of centuries-old interpretive tradition. Many well-meaning Christians seek to resolve the logical dilemmas raised by eternal torment. Thinkers from church history through the present-day nuance Hell and explain its necessity. It is "locked from the inside"[5] and "the dread of hell peoples heaven."[6] They explain how this is just: The souls of men are eternal; The sins of men are an eternal affront to the eternal God; Their punishment must follow from these facts. These theologians probe the Bible and find affirmations of 'eternal fire,' 'eternal punishment,' and 'smoke that rises day and night.' In addition, the souls of the unrighteous 'weep,' 'gnash their teeth,' and 'the smoke of their torment rises forever.' Surely there can be no debate about what the Holy Scriptures reveal on this matter.

A minority group of Christians teaches the lost will be ultimately redeemed from Hell and accepted into heaven. This view is commonly criticized for its failure to portray God as truly just. This view fails to fully resolve the dilemma between God's justice and God's love.

But what if this conundrum had a reasonable solution? What if both versions of Hell Christians have envisioned are inaccurate? An alternate understanding would need to have the support of the Bible, have been historically believed, and resolve the difficulties the traditional view of Hell presents. If this understanding fulfilled those criteria, it would be an acceptable position.

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[4] C.S. Lewis, *The Problem of Pain* (New York: The Macmillan Company, 1947), 106.
[5] C.S. Lewis, *The Problem of Pain*, 115.
[6] E. B. Pusey, *What is of faith as to everlasting punishment?* (Oxford: James Parker & Co, 1880), 19.

This thesis presents such an alternative. This view comports with common sense, emotion, and the character of God described in the Bible. It has been believed historically, and many contemporary Christians have begun to recover its teaching. Most importantly, this view has the full support of God's word—in fact, it interprets scripture more accurately than any other doctrine of Hell. This position does not depend on confusing or misleading hermeneutical principles, but seeks to properly interpret the plain meaning of Scripture.

This view is called conditional immortality. At its root, it teaches that sinners are naturally mortal beings. Eternal life is reserved for God's redeemed children. This view, also called *annihilationism*, declares that the ultimate punishment for sin is death. All men will be raised to God's judgment throne on the final day. Those not found to be in God's book of life will be cast into Hell. There, unbelievers will be destroyed. In other words, the wicked will be *deprived of life*, which includes being *deprived of consciousness*. This thesis, based on conditional immortality, will argue that God punishes the unredeemed with annihilation.

A crucial word to believers before continuing: The issue of Hell is highly divisive. This thesis will suit readers who want to be challenged by a position contrary to their own. Likely, no minds or hearts will be changed in a day. Understanding the support for conditional immortality is relatively simple, but most need time to fully process the implications and weigh the options. Have an open mind while reading this presentation. Most importantly, however, consider how God-fearing, Bible-believing Christians can significantly differ on this topic. The nature of Hell is not a core doctrine worth splitting the unity of Christian brothers. Therefore, this thesis is in no way intended to divide the Church but rather to argue for a specific belief that fellow believers may or may not accept.

The Background

Three major doctrines on the final state of the unredeemed have survived the centuries: traditionalism, universalism, and conditionalism (or annihilationism).[7] Each camp admits the resurrection, the final judgment, and that the wicked will be thrown into fire. The first group and second group tend to believe the human essence—often called a soul—is immortal, while conditionalists believe humans can permanently cease to exist as a living, conscious being. The main point of contention between the camps is *what the fire of Hell does*. Traditionalists believe God will eternally *torture* the unredeemed. Universalists believe God will temporarily *purify* sinners with fire, eventually bringing them to *reconciliation*. Conditionalists believe God will *annihilate* the wicked.[8]

The Westminster Confession of faith states the traditionalist view of the soul as follows: "The bodies of men, after death, return to dust, and see corruption: but their souls, which neither die nor sleep, having an immortal subsistence, immediately return to God who gave them."[9] The human soul is permanently conscious, and those who do not accept God's grace face damnation in Hell, which is a place of everlasting torment. Although the doctrines of the soul's immortality and eternal conscious torment in Hell are correlated, the former is not necessary to believe the latter.[10] For example, souls may be naturally mortal but God will eternally sustain them in Hell.

Universalists reverse the narrative, explaining that, although the soul is immortal, it will *not* be permanently stuck in Hell. God purifies sinners through Hell's fire, ultimately reconciling

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[7] Le Roy Edwin Froom, *The Conditionalist Faith of our Fathers : The Conflict of the Ages Over the Nature and Destiny of Man* (Washington, D.C.: Review and Herald, 1966), 12.

[8] J. H. Pettingell, *The Theological Tri-lemma, The Threefold Question of Endless Misery, Universal Salvation, Or Conditional Immortality Considered in the Light of Reason, Nature and Revelation* (New York: Sherwood & Co., 1878), 15.

[9] The Orthodox Presbyterian Church, *The Westminster Confession of Faith and Catechisms* (Lawrenceville, Georgia: Christian Education & Publications), 2007, 147.

[10] Robert A Peterson, *Hell on Trial: The Case for Eternal Punishment* (Phillipsburg, N.J.: P&R Publishing, 1995), 178.

them to Himself. [11] *All* will—or at least *can*—eventually make their way to heaven through God's grace. As put by Charles Watson, "Christian Universalists believe that grace is available for everyone and perpetually so."[12]

Annihilationism, or 'conditional immortality,' claims that immortality is not an inherent aspect of every human being, but is a gift from God to the saved.[13] Hell's fire, therefore, encompasses not only elements of pain but also the final consuming of the mortal being in death.

It is worth mentioning the areas that are *not* in dispute. Each belief can be supported with Scripture, and many if not most of the advocates from each camp attempt to do so. All camps agree in a resurrection of the wicked. No side holds a definite position on the parts of a being, including physicalism, dichotomy, or trichotomy. Regardless of the soul's division, the *whole being* of a sinner will be tortured, finally redeemed, or annihilated in Hell. Monergism versus Synergism (or Calvinism versus Arminianism) is also not a point determined by any party within this debate. Just as some traditionalists agree on Hell but disagree on determinism, so may conditionalists and universalists differ. Importantly, the intermediate state is also not up for dispute.[14] This is an often misunderstood point. The state of the lost *before* judgment day is not determined by any of the three views. For example, a universalist may believe the wicked are tormented in the intermediate state while another universalist holds they are unconscious. Both agree, however, that once in the *final* state, the wicked always have a chance to accept mercy. In addition, detail-specific questions such as Hell's size and location or the pain's intensity and

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[11] David Bentley Hart, *That All Shall be Saved: Heaven, Hell, and Universal Salvation* (New Haven, Connecticut: Yale University Press, 2019), 1.

[12] Charles Watson Sr., *Hell in a Nutshell: The Mystery of His Will.* (Eugene, Oregon: Resource Publications, 2016) Chapter 9.

[13]Glenn A. Peoples, "Introduction to Evangelical Conditionalism," in *Rethinking Hell*, ed. Christopher M. Date (Eugene, Oregon: Wipf and Stock Publishers).

[14] Edward W. Fudge, *The Fire that Consumes: A Biblical and Historical Study of the Doctrine of Final Punishment* (Eugene, Oregon: Cascade Books, 2011), 366-367.

form are irrelevant. One may believe differently in any of these areas and remain a traditionalist, universalist, or conditionalist.

In special dispute between all three camps is the Greek word 'Aiōnios' translated to 'eternal' in English. Fudge asks, "Does aiōnios describe time in unending duration ("everlasting"), some unknown quality of the age to come ("eternal"), both of these, or neither of them?"[15] Traditionalism places emphasis on duration, arguing that aiōnios refers to an unending period of time. Conditionalism accepts this as a possible translation of the word, but the truth or falsity of conditionalism does not depend on either translation of the word. Universalists argue that aiōnios usually never indicates duration and normally only refers to the 'future-age' quality of the punishment sinners will receive.[16]

Classical thinkers throughout history have presented various opinions on the final judgment. Many of the greatest theologians recognized today were traditionalists, including Augustine,[17] John Calvin,[18] and C.S. Lewis.[19] Traditionalists argue this strong history of confirmation lends them the home-field advantage. One must be careful "departing from what has been held 'always, by everybody, everywhere.'" [20]

Universalists respond that earlier Christian history was in their favor.[21] They point out various early universalist writers such as Origen of Alexandria and Gregory of Nyssa.[22] Universalism has always existed in some form throughout Christian history, even if in the minority. This early historical basis argues in favor of continued support for universalism.

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[15] Fudge, *The Fire That Consumes*, 33-34.
[16] Watson, *Hell in a Nutshell*, Chapter 4.
[17] Augustine, *City of God* (New York: Modern Library, 1993), Book XXI.
[18] John Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion* (Louisville, Kentucky: Westminster John Knox Press, 2006), Book 3, Chapter 25, Section 12.
[19] C.S. Lewis, *The Problem Of Pain*, 106-116.
[20] John Blanchard, Whatever Happened to Hell? (Darlington, Co. Durham, England: Evangelical Press, 1993), 214.
[21] Hart, *That All Shall be Saved*, 1.
[22] Watson, *Hell in a Nutshell*, Appendix C.

Conditionalists likewise claim historical backing from early church fathers such as Clement of Rome and Ignatius of Antioch.[23] Conditionalists and universalists also cite the central principle of the Reformation: If the Bible really says it, why should tradition override God's revelation?[24]

The progression of each view dates back far into history. Scholars heavily debate what the Old Testament and New Testament actually taught on the subject of final punishment and the soul, as has already been mentioned and will be expounded on throughout this thesis. In the wider culture of the world, the concept of an immortal soul can be traced to philosophers such as Plato.[25] Conditionalists argue that Plato's teaching began to blend with Scripture during the intertestamental period[26] and finally solidified in the second century A.D.[27] When Platonic influence is argued against traditionalists, they respond that with or without Plato's influence, the Bible still supports eternal conscious torment.[28] Augustine, who greatly influenced Christendom, wrote in favor of eternal torment. The traditional view of Hell won out during the Reformation, with thinkers such as Calvin and Luther affirming the doctrine.[29]

As a whole, universalist and annihilationist ideas received initial acceptance and development in the community of Christian thought.[30] Interest continued throughout history, although traditionalism has garnered the largest amount of mainstream support. Understanding the history of Hell as a doctrine is imperative, as it strengthens or weakens the Biblical arguments on all three sides of the issue.

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[23] Dr. John H. Roller, *The Doctrine of Immortality in the Early Church* (self-pub., John H. Roller, 2008), 11-24.

[24] Fudge, *Fire that Consumes*, 9-16.

[25] Fudge, *Fire that Consumes,* 19.

[26] Fudge, *Fire that Consumes,* 113-115.

[27] "The Origin of Hell-Fire in Christian Teaching," Truth According to Scripture, accessed Jan. 19, 2024, www.truthaccordingtoscripture.com/documents/death/origin-of-hell-fire.php.

[28] Peterson, *Hell on Trial*, 177.

[29] Fudge, *Fire that Consumes*, 314-316.

[30] Robin A. Parry, "A Universalist View," in *Four Views of Hell*, ed. Preston Sprinkle (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 2016), 101.

One thing to mention regards the biblical words for Hell. The Bible uses four distinct words that are often translated as Hell. These are Sheol, Hades, Gehenna, and Tartarus.[31] Sheol is the Hebrew word frequently used in the Old Testament to describe the intermediate state. Both the wicked and the unrighteous go here. For the purposes of this thesis, Sheol is not considered 'Hell' since it does not relate to the final judgment of the unsaved. Hades is a Greek word that functionally replicates the word Sheol. Tartarus is a rarely used and confusing word that 2 Peter uses to talk about the holding cell of demons. Once again, this word has no relevance to the topic at hand. Finally, Gehenna. This is the word commonly used to describe Hell. It literally means the valley of Hinnom, a physical location outside Jerusalem.[32] When used by Jesus it seems to take on the meaning of the final place of judgment. Some other phrases or imagery also refer to Hell, like the 'lake of fire'[33] or 'the outer darkness.'[34]

In passing, one term should be clarified as well. When the conditionalist uses the term 'annihilation,' this does not refer to complete subatomic deletion of an object, but rather to the basic result of fire burning something to ashes. Annihilation includes the removal of conscious activity. Joseph Dear writes, "the claim that the unsaved are done away with, made dead in every sense of the word, does not require the absolute cosmic uncreation of everything that made them up."[35] An animal corpse would be considered *annihilated* within this definition.

Division of the Thesis

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[31] Joseph Dear, *The Bible Teaches Annihilationism* (2020), 33.
[32] Dear, *The Bible Teaches Annihilationism,* 35.
[33] Rev. 20:15.
[34] Matt. 8:12.
[35] Dear, *The Bible Teaches Annihilationism*, 26.

The argument that follows will revolve around reading and interpreting portions of Scripture. Objections will be addressed periodically. The objections raised are intended to be *representative*, not *comprehensive*.

The question of the immortality of the soul will be dealt with first. This issue is not decisive but has immense implications to the thought surrounding the issue of Hell. This same section will include evidence that supports the destruction of the human soul initiated by sin. Second, this thesis will outline a positive case for conditional immortality through the narratives of the Bible and the Bible's own interpretation of said narratives. Third, the scriptural proofs for the traditional view will be responded to. Fourth, a case will be presented in favor of conditional immortality based on verses stating life is reserved only for the saved. Fifth, this thesis will consider imagery regarding the final judgment and argue they have been misinterpreted. Sixth, it will be shown how the concepts of sacrifice and atonement support annihilationism. Seventh, a major objection against the interpretation of certain key phrases will be responded to. Eighth, traditionalist arguments against conditional immortality will be responded to. Ninth, this thesis will defend against universalist critiques of conditionalism. Finally, this work will conclude with the impact of the conditionalist doctrine to the life and outlook of a Christian.

The Immortal Soul

Evangelicals today generally believe a major biblical misconception. The traditional doctrine teaches that human souls are immortal. Pastors often describe the human being as a ray that continues forever: The earthly life is a tiny fragment of the eternal, continuing soul.[36] This metaphor sounds deep—and super religious. However, a problem remains: The Bible never

[36] Francis Chan, "Living Eternally," Cornerstone Church in Simi Valley, California, YouTube video on March 8, 2009, https://youtu.be/86dsfBbZfWs?si=_2tflpsN0RVs1Yns.

teaches it. When pressed, adherents of the immortal soul doctrine admit the apparent absence of their teaching from the Word of God but claim it is "everywhere assumed."[37] Yet, if the Bible really holds this doctrine subliminally, we should not expect it to claim otherwise. Yet, many scriptural passages directly say the soul is *not* immortal.

The Holy Bible is clear from the first pages that humans are mortal beings. Genesis chapters one through three outline the creation story, including the formation and exile of man from the garden of Eden. Genesis 2:7 says, "...the Lord God formed man of the dust of the ground, and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life; and man became a living being."[38] The creation act encompasses the entire living being. However, God's 'breath of life' did not induce man to live forever with no dependencies. In Genesis 2:9, God places 'The tree of life' in the midst of the garden. According to the next chapter of Genesis, man cannot live forever without this tree. Genesis 3:22-24:

> Then the Lord God said, "Behold, the man has become like one of Us, to know good and evil. And now, lest he put out his hand and take also of the tree of life, and eat, and live forever"— therefore the Lord God sent him out of the garden of Eden to till the ground from which he was taken. So He drove out the man; and He placed cherubim at the east of the garden of Eden, and a flaming sword which turned every way, to guard the way to the tree of life.[39]

Man cannot obtain immortality without God's provision, represented by the tree of life. At the very end of the Bible when the saved are rejoined with God, the tree of life reappears.

Revelation 22:2-3 states,

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[37] William Greenough Thayer Shedd, *The Doctrine of Endless Punishment* (New York: Scribner, 1886), 51.
[38] Gen. 2:7, New King James Version.
[39] Gen. 3:22-24.

> In the middle of its street, and on either side of the river, was the tree of life, which bore twelve fruits, each tree yielding its fruit every month. The leaves of the tree were for the healing of the nations. And there shall be no more curse, but the throne of God and of the Lamb shall be in it, and His servants shall serve Him.[40]

So God's Word presents powerfully the concept of *dependency*. Mankind has no ability to sustain life without God's provision. The passage from Revelation 22 describes "the curse" being removed. This also refers back to the opening chapters of Genesis. God lists several punishments for mankind's disobedience, one of which follows:

> In the sweat of your face you shall eat bread
> Till you return to the ground,
> For out of it you were taken;
> For dust you are,
> And to dust you shall return.[41]

As seen earlier in Genesis, man was formed of dust: able to be destroyed if God chose it. Not only is God *able* to return man to dust, but he declares he *will* do so when mankind sins. The consequence of sin is death. This equation reappears over and over throughout Scripture.

The Book of Psalms declares man's destructibility. Psalm 1, after describing the flourishing continuance of the righteous, says:

> The ungodly are not so,
> But are like the chaff which the wind drives away.
> Therefore the ungodly shall not stand in the judgment,
> Nor sinners in the congregation of the righteous.
> For the Lord knows the way of the righteous,

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[40] Rev. 22:2-3.
[41] Gen. 3:19.

> But the way of the ungodly shall perish.[42]

God once again reveals his equation for justice, this time through the Psalms: The wicked will perish. They are compared to 'chaff'— worthless bits of dust that are blown away by the wind.

The Psalms are rich in this category of imagery. An incomplete list includes Psalm 2:9, 12; Psalm 5:4-6; Psalm 6:5, 10; Psalm 7:11-16; Psalm 9:3-6; Psalm 11:5-6; Psalm 18:8, 37-42; Psalm 20:8; Psalm 21:8-12; Psalm 37; Psalm 49; Psalm 52; Psalm 73:18-19, 27; Psalm 90:3-6; Psalm 92:6-9; Psalm 104:11-18; and Psalm 112:10. A casual stroll through these verses reveals statements such as "[God] shall destroy those who speak falsehood,"[43] "When my enemies turn back, They shall fall and perish at Your presence,"[44] and "The Lord shall swallow them up in His wrath, And the fire shall devour them."[45]

While many psalms affirm this truth, Psalm 37 is particularly potent in its description of the temporality of the wicked. Here are several excerpts to show the verses are not being misused in any way. Psalm 37:1-2:

> Do not fret because of evildoers,
> Nor be envious of the workers of iniquity.
> For they shall soon be cut down like the grass,
> And wither as the green herb.[46]

Psalm 37:9-11:

> For evildoers shall be cut off;
> But those who wait on the Lord,

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[42] Ps. 1:4-6.
[43] Ps. 5:6.
[44] Ps. 9:3.
[45] Ps. 21:9.
[46] Ps. 37:1-2.

> They shall inherit the earth.
> For yet a little while and the wicked shall be no more;
> Indeed, you will look carefully for his place,
> But it shall be no more.
> But the meek shall inherit the earth,
> And shall delight themselves in the abundance of peace.[47]

Psalm 37:34-38:

> Wait on the Lord,
> And keep His way,
> And He shall exalt you to inherit the land;
> When the wicked are cut off, you shall see it.
> I have seen the wicked in great power,
> And spreading himself like a native green tree.
> Yet he passed away, and behold, he was no more;
> Indeed I sought him, but he could not be found.
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> Mark the blameless man, and observe the upright;
> For the future of that man is peace.
> But the transgressors shall be destroyed together;
> The future of the wicked shall be cut off.[48]

The indisputable language of withering, non-existence, destruction, and being cut off stands in stark contrast to the bold claims that man never withers, always exists, never is destroyed, and continues on forever.

Nearly every book of the Bible explicitly agrees with this principle, with the remaining authors silent on the matter. Many of these scriptures will be examined shortly. What about verses that seem to support inherent immortality?

The Westminster Confession of Faith, (WCF) written in 1646, states in Chapter 32, "The bodies of men after death return to dust, and see corruption; but their souls (which neither die nor

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[47] Ps. 37:9-11.
[48] Ps. 37:34-38.

sleep), having an immortal subsistence, immediately return to God who gave them."[49] What is the justification for their claim? The Westminster Confession of Faith originally had no proof texts because "most of the particulars, being received truths among all churches, there was seldom any debate about the truth or falsehood of any article or clause." [50] Church tradition, not careful study of the scriptures, governed the WCF. Later, proof texts were added.

To support the claim that "The bodies of men after death return to dust, and see corruption," the Westminster Assembly cites Genesis 3:19 and Acts 13:36, both of which refer to humans dying. The writers of the Confession interpreted these verses to implicate only the body's destruction. The text itself, however, never indicates a soul-body division with a separate fate for each component. Had God in his omniscience and inspiration of scripture wanted to impart this knowledge, he could have done so in a single phrase. However, He never makes this distinction.

The WCF cites Luke 23:43 and Ecclesiastes 12:7 to support the claim that souls "neither die nor sleep" and have an "immortal subsistence."[51] In Luke 23, Jesus is being crucified next to the two criminals. One criminal mocks Him, but the other objects, and asks Jesus to remember him when He inherits His kingdom. Luke 23:43: "...Jesus said to him, 'Assuredly, I say to you, today you will be with Me in Paradise.'"[52] Some conditionalists argue that Jesus's statement 'today you will be with Me' does not refer to literal time, but reflects the criminal's perception of being with Christ after the resurrection.[53] Even without this possible interpretation, Luke 23:43 still does not prove what the WCF wants it to prove. It never states all souls are immortal, nor that they cannot sleep in any circumstance. Rather, it simply explains that one particular *believer*

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[49] The Orthodox Presbyterian Church, *The Westminster Confession*, 147.

[50] Alexander F. Mitchell. *The Westminster Assembly: Its History and Standards* (Puritan Publications, 2012), 377-378.

[51] The Orthodox Presbyterian Church, *The Westminster Confession*, 147.

[52] Luke 23:43.

[53] Dear, *The Bible Teaches Annihilationism*, 39-40.

was with Christ after death. Conditionalists may easily accept this as fully consistent with their doctrinal stance on the final destruction of the wicked, even if Jesus's words are not considered to be figurative.

Ecclesiastes 12:7 explains that upon death, "[The] dust will return to the earth as it was, And the spirit will return to God who gave it."[54] Again, the text must be stretched to make the point. The spirit returning to God does not mean every human has an immortal, indestructible soul. In fact, Ecclesiastes uses the same Hebrew word for 'breath,' which corresponds to the 'breath of life' given to mankind in Genesis.[55] Essentially, Ecclesiastes says 'the body leaves, and the life force within leaves too.' This interpretation is far more consistent with the rest of Ecclesiastes, which includes affirmations such as "[It] will not be well with the wicked; nor will he prolong his days, which are as a shadow…"[56] or "the living know that they will die; But the dead know nothing."[57]

To return to the original point, the Westminster Assembly claimed that souls "neither die nor sleep."[58] As seen, their justification was lacking and dependent on many layers of assumptions. The Bible, however, reveals that reality is directly opposite to the Confession's claims. Ezekiel 18:4 says, "The soul who sins shall die."[59] James 5:20 explains that "...he who turns a sinner from the error of his way will save a soul from death and cover a multitude of sins."[60] And finally, Matthew 10:28 says, "...do not fear those who kill the body but cannot kill the soul. Rather fear him who can destroy both soul and body in hell."[61] So souls certainly *can* die and *will* die when God judges them. The claim that souls cannot sleep is easily disputed by

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[54] Eccles. 12:7.
[55] Dear, *The Bible Teaches Annihilationism,* 92-93.
[56] Eccles. 8:13.
[57] Eccles. 9:5.
[58] The Orthodox Presbyterian Church, *The Westminster Confession*, 147.
[59] Ezek. 18:4.
[60] James 5:20.
[61] Matt. 10:28.

several examples such as 1 Thessalonians 4:14, Matthew 9:24, Psalm 6:5, or John 11:11-14. However, such rebuttal is unnecessary for the present debate. The issue at hand pertains to the state of the lost *after* the resurrection, not before.

Modern traditionalists also have proof texts for the immortal soul. John Blanchard[62] cites Genesis 1:27, which says man is made in "the image of God." While a powerful text for many other theological truths, Genesis 1:27 simply does not mean humans are immortal as God is. Many attributes of God are *not* inherited by humans, such as his sovereignty or omniscience. In fact, Christians *know* immortality is an 'unshared' attribute of God because 1 Timothy 6:16 says "God…alone has immortality," meaning He is the only one who is inherently immortal. God is life itself, and the source of eternal life to those who accept His salvation. Jesus describes himself as "the way, the truth, and the life," and adds "no one comes to the Father except through Me." (John 14:6) If Jesus is the life, mankind cannot live apart from His will, and can only receive eternal life through Him. In fact, all the wicked who still live today are upheld only by God's common grace to all men. 2 Peter 9 says, "The Lord is not slack concerning His promise, as some count slackness, but is longsuffering toward us, not willing that any should perish but that all should come to repentance." God allows wicked men to continue existing in this world only that they may eventually come to repentance. Without that, they will 'perish.'

In addition, Blanchard claims support from Ecclesiastes 3:11,[63] which says "He has also set eternity in the human heart."[64] Blanchard interprets this to mean that man is immortal. However, he conveniently leaves out the context of Ecclesiastes 3, which says in verse 20, "All go to the same place; all come from dust, and to dust all return."[65] Even a first-glance reading

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[62] Blanchard, *Whatever Happened to Hell?*, 215.
[63] Blanchard, *Whatever Happened to Hell?,* 215.
[64] Ecc. 3:11, NIV.
[65] Ecc. 3:20.

provides an alternate, superior interpretation: Mankind has a deep desire to live forever, but this desire is not granted. Today, Christians see the purpose of mankind is fulfilled through Jesus's gift of life.[66]

The Bible has a clear and consistent message demonstrated through Genesis, Revelation, Psalms, and many more places: Man is dependent on God, not immortal by nature. When they rebel against their Creator, He will end their life. This judgment act includes both soul and body. Proof for immortal soul theology falls flat as Scriptural support must be stretched to reach any of its conclusions. Humans are not immortal by nature and will die without salvation from their sins. Romans 6:23 summarizes: "The wages of sin is death."

Narratives of Destruction

A key part of God's formula for justice has already been discussed: Sin earns death. Often, Scripture phrases this truth in other ways to clarify its meaning. God warns that the wicked will perish, cease, burn up, be cut off, and be destroyed. Importantly, he reveals His justice in clear and understandable terms, often utilizing stories to demonstrate His character.

Genesis 1-3 revealed that God curses sin with death. The rest of Genesis follows suit. Immediately before the flood narrative of Genesis 6-7, "the Lord saw that the wickedness of man was great in the earth, and that every intent of the thoughts of his heart was only evil continually."[67] Therefore, God promises to "destroy man whom I have created from the face of the earth."[68] He saves only Noah and his family from this fate of complete destruction. We can imagine the suffering, angst, and anger as the wicked world drowned in God's judgment act.

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[66] Dear, *The Bible Teaches Annihilationism*, 60.
[67] Gen. 6:5.
[68] Gen. 6:7.

However, such pain ended in a short time, replaced by death. This powerful narrative displays God's response to sin: destruction.

Genesis 18-19 provides a similar narrative. The men of Sodom and Gomorrah are wicked, practicing sexual immorality and violence. Because of this sin, God enacts judgment. In this story, rather than *water*, God annihilates his enemies through *fire*. Genesis 19:24-25 narrates: "Then the Lord rained brimstone and fire on Sodom and Gomorrah, from the Lord out of the heavens. So He overthrew those cities, all the plain, all the inhabitants of the cities, and what grew on the ground."[69] The message is clear once again: sin earns consuming fire.

A skeptic may wonder whether using stories from Genesis is a stretch. Perhaps God acts towards mankind differently now. Maybe the literal destruction of the Old Testament is replaced by eternal torment in the New Testament, while called by the same name. Or feasibly, the stories apply only to the physical *body* while the *souls* of men really do receive eternal torment.

All these questions are put to rest by the New Testament's own interpretation of the events in these two stories. 2 Peter 2:4-9:

> For if God…did not spare the ancient world, but saved Noah, one of eight people, a preacher of righteousness, bringing in the flood on the world of the ungodly; and turning the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah into ashes, condemned them to destruction, making them an example to those who afterward would live ungodly; and delivered righteous Lot, who was oppressed by the filthy conduct of the wicked…then the Lord knows how to deliver the godly out of temptations and to reserve the unjust under punishment for the day of judgment…[70]

Explaining further, Peter says: "those who walk according to the flesh…[are] like natural brute beasts made to be caught and destroyed...and will utterly perish in their own corruption."[71] This

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[69] Gen. 19:24-25.
[70] 2 Pet. 2:4-9.
[71] 2 Pet. 2:10, 12.

answers the objections raised above. Even within the full revelation of the New Testament, God retains His equation for justice: sinners will perish. Peter never says only the *body* of men perish, nor that the *souls* of men will live on. If this were true, God's word would be leaving out an essential detail related to the destiny of the wicked. In addition, Peter uses 'destruction' in the same way Genesis uses it. In fact, Peter uses the stories of the flood and Sodom to *explain* how God will punish men in the future. Conditionalists follow his example in using the Old Testament examples of God's justice to frame and explain the final punishment God will enact on the wicked.

Later, we will see how traditionalists attempt to support their view with the biblical phrase 'eternal fire.' Supposedly, if fire is 'eternal' then it must have an eternal fuel: Thus, endless misery in Hell. Tertullian writes, "If, therefore, any one shall violently suppose that the destruction of the soul and the flesh in hell amounts to a final annihilation…let him recollect that the fire of hell is eternal…He will then come to the conclusion that substances must be eternal, when their penal killing is an eternal one."[72] Does eternal fire really indicate this? It is worth pausing here to read another applicable description of the Genesis narratives found in Jude 1:5-7:

> But I want to remind you…that the Lord, having saved the people out of the land of Egypt, afterward destroyed those who did not believe…as Sodom and Gomorrah, and the cities around them in a similar manner to these, having given themselves over to sexual immorality and gone after strange flesh, are set forth as an example, suffering the vengeance of eternal fire.[73]

Once again, the New Testament uses Old Testament narratives to explain the consequence of sin. Jude says the destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah means they are set forth an example "suffering the vengeance of eternal fire." We *could* say this means their souls are alive, suffering

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[72] Tertullian, *On the Resurrection of the Flesh* (New York: The Macmillan company, 1922), Chapter 35.
[73] Jude 1:5-7.

torment forever. Such an interpretation must read implications into the text that are never stated. Understood naturally, Sodom's complete and utter destruction—continuing to this day—*is* the 'vengeance' inflicted by 'eternal fire'. In explanation, the *eternal* does not refer to the fire's duration while burning something, but rather the unbeatable power it has to eternally remove its victim. Within the story, the wicked men of Sodom were completely decimated. They remain gone, perished, and absent from the face of the earth to this day. Such a reading of eternal fire comports much better with the 2 Peter language of "ashes, condemned…to destruction."[74]

Perhaps most importantly of all, the Lord Jesus Himself explains the lesson of the flood and Sodom narratives as it relates to the last days. In Luke 17:26-29 Jesus says,

> And as it was in the days of Noah, so it will be also in the days of the Son of Man: They ate, they drank, they married wives, they were given in marriage, until the day that Noah entered the ark, and the flood came and destroyed them all. Likewise as it was also in the days of Lot: They ate, they drank, they bought, they sold, they planted, they built; but on the day that Lot went out of Sodom it rained fire and brimstone from heaven and destroyed them all. Even so will it be in the day when the Son of Man is revealed.[75]

Jesus frequently used stories and examples to illustrate his points. The central principle of conditional immortality is no different, as Jesus utilizes the Old Testament narratives of judgment upon sin to demonstrate the swift destruction of His enemies in the last days.

Many other Biblical references repeat this same principle. In Exodus, God's final and ultimate plague upon the hardened people of Egypt is the death of their firstborn children. Shortly after, God drowns Pharoah and his whole army in the Red Sea for their attempt to re-enslave the people of Israel. In Numbers 11, God nearly consumes the Israelites with fire for complaining against God. In Numbers 14, the people of Israel mistrust God and refuse to enter

[74] 2 Pet. 2:6.
[75] Luke 17:26-29.

the promised land, so God forces all of them—except Joshua and Caleb—to wander, die, and be consumed in the desert. The members of Korah's rebellion are met with God's punishment: being swallowed up by the earth and perishing entirely. In Numbers 21, the Israelites utterly destroy the sinful Canaanites. Immediately after, the Israelites also turn to sin, so God sends fiery serpents among them, causing many to die. To save the people, Moses is instructed to erect a bronze serpent. Looking upon this serpent allowed the victim of a serpent to live. Jesus compares himself to the bronze serpent in John 3, the one who is lifted up "that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have eternal life."[76]

Now of course, the scriptures reveal many other stories of sinners who did *not* perish for their sin. These include the murderous Cain, the proud people of Babel, and the rebellious Aaron. However, they *never* receive extended torment as a punishment. In fact, as a general trend the more severe the trespass is, the more likely God judges the sinner with death. Remember Sodom and Gomorrah? Furthermore, even those not punished with death eventually died, since all men are sinners.[77] Notice, also, how the usage of these stories is in no way a rhetorical trick or speculative exercise. God intends narrative to impart deep spiritual truths and often explains the meaning of his own stories. Passages like 2 Peter 2, Jude, and John 3 leave little guesswork as to the intended meaning of the biblical narratives of destruction.

The books of Leviticus and Deuteronomy should be briefly mentioned. These contain God's law for the nation of Israel. Some of the rules are moral and some are ceremonial. The moral laws are further divided into levels of sinfulness. Not every sin committed in Israel would receive a legal penalty. However, the more odious a wicked action was, the more severe the penalty would be. The worst offenses were to be punished with death. For example, Leviticus

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[76] John 3:14.
[77] Rom. 3:23.

20:2-3 says, "Whoever of the children of Israel, or of the strangers who dwell in Israel, who gives any of his descendants to Molech, he shall surely be put to death. The people of the land shall stone him with stones. I will set My face against that man, and will cut him off from his people, because he has given some of his descendants to Molech, to defile My sanctuary and profane My holy name." Another example in verse 10 says, "The man who commits adultery with another man's wife, he who commits adultery with his neighbor's wife, the adulterer and the adulteress, shall surely be put to death." Many more such examples exist. This system of law demonstrates God's character. He does not command the wicked to be tortured for their sins. The penalty is death. Yes, pain may be involved in the process of dying, but the ultimate intent and result was the elimination of the evil persons from Israel. This punishment cleansed God's land from defiling sin.

Of course, the list of biblical evidence around this issue extends far beyond the first five books. In the book of Joshua, God warns Israel not to loot Jericho. When a man named Achan does so, God commands him to be stoned to death in order to prevent the destruction of all Israel.[78] The book of Judges is rife with sin being met by God's wrath. In particular, Judges 19-21 tells the story of the sexual assault and murder of a Levite's concubine being met with military pressure against the tribe of Benjamin. Judges 20:13 explains the people's motivation was to "purge the evil from Israel." God sanctions their attempt to destroy the wicked men of Benjamin. The proper response to sin in God's eyes is the elimination of the sinner. Evil ceases to exist when God exercises his judgment upon it. In 1 Samuel 4-5, the Philistines capture the ark of God, the symbol of His presence. While the ark is in Ashdod, God inflicts the Philistines with tumors. When the ark is sent to the people of Ekron, they receive the same treatment. Due to the plague, many die. In terror they cry out, "Send the ark of the god of Israel away; let it go back to

[78] Josh. 6:18; Josh. 7:1-26.

its own place, or it will kill us and our people."[79] Later in 2 Samuel 6, the Israelites move the same ark of God to Jerusalem. Since they had begun transporting it improperly, the ark begins to fall. A man named Uzzah reaches out to stabilize it, forgetting or ignoring the sacredness of the object representing God's holy presence. Immediately, "...God struck him down, and he died there beside the ark of God."[80] This story reveals the principle once again. God cannot allow evil to remain in His holy presence. Within His chosen people He also has a high standard, wishing to purge and remove evil from among them. In the age to come, God will extend the same standard to the new heaven and new earth. In the end, no more evil will remain in his creation.[81]

The books of 1 and 2 Kings and 1 and 2 Chronicles feature a constant trend of good and bad kings. The worst kings of Israel or Judah often receive destruction on them or their kingdom. An incomplete list of kings visited with death for their wickedness includes Jeroboam,[82] Ahab,[83] Ahaziah,[84] and Jehoram[85]. Rehoboam was attacked by Egypt for turning aside from the Lord. When he repented, "the wrath of the Lord turned from him, so as not to destroy him completely."[86] The trend of evil kings being visited with judgment in the form of destruction reflects the notion that God treats evil with annihilation, not endless misery.

The major prophets fall within the larger story of Israel's rebellion and restoration. Many of the principles contained within these works are applicable to the debate at present, however, because they reveal attributes of God's character. Isaiah, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel contain a treasure trove of verses supporting not endless suffering or universal forgiveness, but *death*, *destruction*,

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[79] 1 Sam. 5:11.
[80] 2 Sam. 6:7.
[81] 1 Cor. 15; Rev. 21.
[82] 2 Chron. 13:14-18.
[83] 1 Kings 22:19-23.
[84] 2 Kings 1:3-4.
[85] 2 Chron. 21:16-20.
[86] 2 Chron. 12:12.

and *consuming fire* as God's retribution for sin and rebellion. The very first chapter of Isaiah contains God's repeated promise to Israel:

> "...If you are willing and obedient,
> You shall eat the good of the land;
> But if you refuse and rebel,
> You shall be devoured by the sword";
> For the mouth of the Lord has spoken.[87]

Moving through Isaiah, God says "The destruction of transgressors and of sinners shall be together, And those who forsake the Lord shall be consumed."[88] After pronouncing woes upon the wicked, Isaiah 5 says, "Therefore, as the fire devours the stubble, And the flame consumes the chaff, So their root will be as rottenness, And their blossom will ascend like dust; …the anger of the Lord is aroused against His people; He has stretched out His hand against them And stricken them, And the hills trembled. Their carcasses were as refuse in the midst of the streets."[89] Hope emerges, however, from the specter of death. Isaiah 9:2, "The people who walked in darkness Have seen a great light; Those who dwelt in the land of the shadow of death, Upon them a light has shined." This hope for overcoming death is revealed to be the Messiah. Isaiah 53 describes the sin-bearing Messiah, fulfilled in Christ. God explains that the suffering and shame Jesus received heals His people. Such suffering included death.

> For He was cut off from the land of the living;
> For the transgressions of My people He was stricken.
> And they made His grave with the wicked—
> But with the rich at His death,
> Because He had done no violence,
> Nor was any deceit in His mouth.[90]

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[87] Isa. 1:19-20.
[88] Isa. 1:28.
[89] Isa. 5:24-25 .
[90] Isa. 53:9.

And again in Isaiah 53,

> Therefore I will divide Him a portion with the great,
> And He shall divide the spoil with the strong,
> Because He poured out His soul unto death,
> And He was numbered with the transgressors,
> And He bore the sin of many,
> And made intercession for the transgressors.[91]

Therefore, the hope for humanity ultimately overcoming sin and its penalty is realized only in the death of Christ. He took the punishment sin deserved. The destruction of Jesus replaces the destruction of mankind. God sees Christ's combined suffering and death as full atonement for the sins of His creation. Thus, the punishment for sin is once again demonstrated to be death, not eternal torment.

Isaiah affirms that God's power is revealed through his *consuming* fire, not *tormenting* fire. Isaiah 33:10-12 says,

> "Now I will rise," says the Lord;
> "Now I will be exalted,
> Now I will lift Myself up.
> You shall conceive chaff,
> You shall bring forth stubble;
> Your breath, as fire, shall devour you.
> And the people shall be like the burnings of lime;
> Like thorns cut up they shall be burned in the fire…"[92]

Stubble and chaff are similar to dust—the very material mankind was created out of. Chaff does not last in fire. It does not stay burning forever. Had God wanted to illustrate eternal torment, He

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[91] Isa. 53:12.
[92] Isa. 33:10-12.

could easily have chosen a metaphor to reflect that. Instead, he chose to represent sinful humans as frail beings doomed to non-existence through fire. Isaiah 33 continues,

> The sinners in Zion are afraid;
> Fearfulness has seized the hypocrites:
> "Who among us shall dwell with the devouring fire?
> Who among us shall dwell with everlasting burnings?"
> He who walks righteously and speaks uprightly,
> He who despises the gain of oppressions,
> Who gestures with his hands, refusing bribes,
> Who stops his ears from hearing of bloodshed,
> And shuts his eyes from seeing evil:
> He will dwell on high;
> His place of defense will be the fortress of rocks;
> Bread will be given him,
> His water will be sure.[93]

Thus, no sinner can dwell with God, who is Himself a consuming fire. Deuteronomy 4:24 says, "For the Lord your God is a consuming fire, a jealous God." Deuteronomy further explains this concept in chapter 9 saying, "Therefore understand today that the Lord your God is He who goes over before you as a consuming fire. He will destroy them and bring them down before you; so you shall drive them out and destroy them quickly, as the Lord has said to you." Only the righteous will be able to continue in God's holy, consuming presence. No person is righteous on their own merit,[94] but Christians can be confident that Jesus's blood covers their sins, enabling them to live in God's presence *now* and in *the world to come*.

The book of Jeremiah recounts God's love for Israel and their rejection of Him. God in His justice must punish them for their sin. That punishment is not torture, but an impending tide of destruction that broke upon Israel soon after Jeremiah was written. God explains, "For My people have committed two evils: They have forsaken Me, the fountain of living waters, And

[93] Isa. 33:14-16.
[94] Eph. 2:8-10.

hewn themselves cisterns—broken cisterns that can hold no water."[95] When the source of life is abandoned, only death can follow. Nevertheless, God gives unique hope to the nation of Israel. God calls them to turn from sin and accept Him, "'Return, backsliding Israel,' says the Lord; 'I will not cause My anger to fall on you. For I am merciful,' says the Lord;'I will not remain angry forever.'"[96] The people continue to rebel. They have "lied about the Lord,"[97] and He responds,

> 'Because you speak this word, Behold, I will make My words in your mouth fire, And this people wood, And it shall devour them. Behold, I will bring a nation against you from afar, O house of Israel,' says the Lord. "It is a mighty nation, It is an ancient nation, A nation whose language you do not know, Nor can you understand what they say. Their quiver is like an open tomb; They are all mighty men. And they shall eat up your harvest and your bread, Which your sons and daughters should eat. They shall eat up your flocks and your herds; They shall eat up your vines and your fig trees; They shall destroy your fortified cities, In which you trust, with the sword…'[98]

This frightening description seems to leave no hope. Is Israel lost? No. God clarifies, "I will not make a complete end of you."[99] This was fulfilled in Israel's temporary destruction and eventual return to the land. Alas, when God speaks of the wicked's end, they are given no such hope. The only way for them to escape is repentance and acceptance of God's salvation *before* their destruction comes.

Ezekiel contains many declarations of God's penalty for sin. Consistent with the rest of the Bible, He promises to end the wicked who rebel against Him. Ezekiel 18 is of particular interest. God responds to a false proverb spoken of His justice. "'The fathers have eaten sour grapes, And the children's teeth are set on edge'" In response, God re-explains how His justice

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[95] Jer. 2:13.
[96] Jer. 3:11.
[97] Jer. 5:12.
[98] Jer. 5:14-17.
[99] Jer. 5:18.

operates. "'Behold, all souls are Mine; The soul of the father As well as the soul of the son is Mine; The soul who sins shall die. But if a man is just And does what is lawful and right; … If he has walked in My statutes And kept My judgments faithfully—He is just; He shall surely live!'"[100] God presents the option between righteousness and wickedness as the option between life and death. He repeats this concept again and again. A wicked son "shall surely die; His blood shall be upon him."[101] A wicked father "shall die for his iniquity."[102] Based on this principle, God pleads, "'Repent, and turn from all your transgressions, so that iniquity will not be your ruin. Cast away from you all the transgressions which you have committed, and get yourselves a new heart and a new spirit. For why should you die, O house of Israel? For I have no pleasure in the death of one who dies,' says the Lord God. 'Therefore turn and live!'" God treats death as the ultimate result of sin. He does not make any statement of eternal torment or of an option to repent after death. Either addition to the text would make God's statements seem misleading and deceptive.

The Lord Jesus uses stories to explain how sin deserves death. Luke 13:1-5 relates a fascinating incident of Jesus using current events to explain spiritual truths.

> There were present at that season some who told Him about the Galileans whose blood Pilate had mingled with their sacrifices. And Jesus answered and said to them, "Do you suppose that these Galileans were worse sinners than all other Galileans, because they suffered such things? I tell you, no; but unless you repent you will all likewise perish. Or those eighteen on whom the tower in Siloam fell and killed them, do you think that they were worse sinners than all other men who dwelt in Jerusalem? I tell you, no; but unless you repent you will all likewise perish.[103]

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[100] Ezek. 18:4-5, 9.
[101] Ezek. 18:13.
[102] Ezek. 18:18.
[103] Luke 13:1-5.

The default destiny for man is destruction. Jesus tactfully removes His audiences' false assumptions by demonstrating that *all* who sin without repentance are headed toward death, not just the worst sinners. Yet notice the complete absence of *torture* as the punishment all are headed toward. Jesus leaves the story at *death*: why should Christians not be content to do likewise?

The meaning behind all these scriptural stories does not comport well with the traditionalist version of God's justice, nor with the ever-forgiving, temporary punishment of the universalist view. The narrative of God's word speaks to the decimation of evil through punitive destruction.

Traditionalist Proofs Refuted

The traditionalist view declares the final state to be eternal conscious torment. Many Christians, having been taught this doctrine all their lives, mingle false preconceived notions with scriptural interpretation.[104] Several proof texts initially appear to support the eternal torment position. However, upon applying critical thought and allowing Scripture to interpret Scripture, the facade melts to reveal the same truth the rest of God's word teaches.

The traditional view claims Matthew 25:31-46 as a proof text. In this passage, Jesus first explains that when the Son of Man comes in His glory, He will separate the 'sheep' and the 'goats.' He then explains these two categories. The former showed hospitality and kindness to the least of the brothers or sisters, and these things were done for the Son of Man. Next, speaking of the goats, He says, "...Depart from me, you who are cursed, into the eternal fire prepared for the devil and his angels…Then they will go away to eternal punishment, but the righteous to

[104] Dear, *The Bible Teaches Annihilationism,* 43.

eternal life."[105] Many Christians with preconceived notions will read this verse and shut their Bibles. Two elements here appear to support the traditional view: 'eternal fire prepared for the devil' and 'eternal punishment.' Neither phrase, when critically examined, supports eternal torment.

As previously seen in the book of Jude, 'eternal fire' does not refer to torture but rather to complete and utter destruction, demonstrated through Sodom and Gomorrah. Simply because the fire is described as eternal does not necessarily mean the fire itself lasts forever. The word 'eternal' refers to, firstly, the quality of the fire's source: God, who is eternal; and secondly, to the effect of the fire: eternal destruction.[106] Such an interpretation is evidenced also by Hebrews 12:29 which says, "Our God is a consuming fire."[107] Even if the duration of the fire *is* eternal, the implication that humans last forever in it is unsubstantiated and averse to common sense. Most importantly, numerous scriptural passages directly contradict this interpretation, as shown previously.

The debate over "eternal punishment" comes down to the definition of punishment. In the conditionalist view, *non-existence* is a punishment which never ends. This point cannot be understated; The Bible makes a point of the eternality of the destruction of unbelievers because they will never be resurrected a second time. The second death is final. The conditionalist interpretation of eternal punishment as eternal destruction is far superior to the eternal torment option. This definition comports with the rest of the scripture, including the words of Jesus. In Matthew 10:28, Christ says, "Do not be afraid of those who kill the body but cannot kill the soul. Rather, be afraid of the One who can destroy both soul and body in hell."[108] Paul says in Romans

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[105] Matthew 25:41, 46.
[106] Dear, *The Bible Teaches Annihilationism,* 215-221.
[107] Heb. 12:29.
[108] Matthew 10:28.

6:23, "The wages of sin is death."[109] If the wages of sin is death, the wages of sin is destruction, and the wages of sin is eternal punishment, this means that eternal punishment *is* death and destruction. The Bible does not contradict itself. If Hell is the place where the entire being *dies* and is *destroyed*, then it cannot also be a place where the being is tormented forever and ever.

In order to invalidate the conditionalist interpretation, traditionalists attempt to argue a restricted definition of punishment. Alan Gomes writes, "Someone cannot be punished eternally unless that someone is there to receive the punishment."[110] The requirement for punishment to be experienced is poor and inconsistently applied. Receiving *painful* paper cuts is a far less severe punishment than dying with a *painless* lethal injection. 'Feeling' something is not the sole measure of punishment. Imagine a criminal's arm is cut off while he is asleep. Drugs remove all pain from his body until the wound is fully healed. Did the criminal undergo punishment? Of course he did! The removal of his arm is a severe penalty. Yet, the traditionalist definition of eternal punishment forgoes even this natural conclusion or inconsistently applies it when talking about final punishment. If death is not a terrible state for any human to enter—worthy of being considered a penalty—then the passing of a loved one is of no concern. If death is not a punishment, then why do court systems hold capital punishment as the most extreme penalty for crimes? The traditionalist's exclusion of death from the definition of punishment fails to comport with reality.

An objection is raised to the proposition that death, destruction, and eternal punishment are equal. Perhaps the equation works the other way, where *death* and *destruction* are defined by eternal punishment. These could be words to indicate the eternal misery of the lost. Under this view, death would be a 'gateway' or merely 'separation' from God. The problem with this

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[109] Rom. 6:23.

[110] Alan W. Gomes, "Evangelicals and the Annihilation of Hell Part Two" (Christian Research Journal, 1991), 7.

argument is that the words 'death' and 'destruction' are defined and described throughout the Bible, whereas 'eternal punishment' receives little description. First, the Bible certainly supports the idea that sin, through death, leads to exclusion and 'separation' from God. One should question how sinners can continue to live while separated from the source of life itself.[111] Why should the wicked continue to indefinitely survive in 'the outer darkness'[112]? To reach this conclusion, one must assume the indestructibility of the soul. Second, 'destruction' is described as annihilation within the Bible. This will be discussed in the section titled 'interpretative pitfalls'. Third, death is not treated as a 'gateway' within the Bible. *Resurrection* is the gateway. Ecclesiastes 9:5 says, "For the living know that they will die; But the dead know nothing, And they have no more reward, For the memory of them is forgotten."[113] David declares in Psalm 6:5, "For in death there is no remembrance of you; in Sheol who will give you praise?"[114] Sheol is the shadowy place after death and before resurrection. The Bible certainly treats death like an *obstacle*, not a *path* to life. Psalm 16:10 says, "For you will not abandon my soul to Sheol, or let your holy one see corruption."[115] Job 7:21 says, "Why then do You not pardon my transgression, And take away my iniquity? For now I will lie down in the dust, And You will seek me diligently, But I will no longer be."[116] Job certainly viewed death as non-existence in saying after death he will 'no longer be.' Again, Job declares, "But man dies and is laid away; Indeed he breathes his last, And where is he? As water disappears from the sea, And a river becomes parched and dries up, So man lies down and does not rise. Till the heavens are no more, They will not awake Nor be roused from their sleep."[117] Even in Job, there is a hint of something to

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[111] Gen. 2:7; John 1:1-5; John 14:6, Rev. 22:1.
[112] Matt. 8:12; Matt. 22:13; Matt. 25:30.
[113] Ecc. 9:5.
[114] Ps. 6:5, ESV.
[115] Ps. 16:10.
[116] Job 7:21.
[117] Job 14:10-12.

overcome death. Men will wake in the resurrection. *This* is the ultimate hope for new life. Paul goes into great detail in 1 Thessalonians 4:13-18,

> But I do not want you to be ignorant, brethren, concerning those who have fallen asleep, lest you sorrow as others who have no hope. For if we believe that Jesus died and rose again, even so God will bring with Him those who sleep in Jesus. For this we say to you by the word of the Lord, that we who are alive and remain until the coming of the Lord will by no means precede those who are asleep. For the Lord Himself will descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of an archangel, and with the trumpet of God. And the dead in Christ will rise first. Then we who are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air. And thus we shall always be with the Lord. Therefore comfort one another with these words.[118]

Death is treated as the *obstacle* that must be overcome by resurrection to initiate everlasting life. The traditionalist may object, 'all men, including the wicked, are resurrected.' This is true, but in a different sense. All will be raised, but only the righteous will be raised to *life*,[119] while the wicked will be raised for the opposite purpose.

Returning to Matthew 25, Jesus said the wicked will go into 'eternal punishment'. If eternal punishment is the penalty for sin, and death is also the penalty for sin, then eternal punishment *is* death. If death is the punishment for sin, and death is non-existence and non-awareness, then the punishment for sin *is* non-existence and non-awareness. Therefore: Eternal punishment *is* non-existence and non-awareness. In other words, the wicked are annihilated.

This definition is consistent and reasonable. Although pain *can* be a penalty, so can the loss of something good. In this case, to die forever is to lose fellowship with God, fellowship with mankind, and experience of every good thing—for the rest of eternity. Augustine, although

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[118] 1 Thess. 4:13-18.
[119] Dan. 12:2; John 5:29.

a traditionalist, provides deep insight: "When a very serious crime is punished by death and the execution of the sentence takes only a minute, no laws consider that minute as the measure of the punishment, but rather the fact that the criminal is forever removed from the community of the living."[120] The wicked are forever removed from the community of God and His servants. Their punishment is certainly never-ending.

Mark 9:47-48 is commonly claimed for the traditional view of Hell. In this passage, Jesus quotes Isaiah 66 describing Hell, "'Their worm does not die, And the fire is not quenched.'"[121] Traditionalists believe these are clear indicators of unending torment. The text does not actually say or imply this. Worms and fire are both examples of destructive agents—worms do not torture living people—they consume dead ones. In fact, looking back on the passage quoted by Jesus, this is exactly what is happening. Isaiah 66:24 reads, "And they shall go forth and look Upon the corpses of the men who have transgressed."[122] These are not living souls; they are dead ones being ultimately consumed and perishing as a result of their sin. Traditionalists also read the words *as if* they said 'ever-living worms' or 'never-ending fire.' In reality, the modifiers 'not dying' and 'not being quenched' are used to describe the worms *during the process of consumption*, telling the reader that the annihilation process will certainly be completed without interruption. Stott writes, "Jesus' use of Isa 66:24 does not mention everlasting pain. What he says is that the worm will not die and the fire will not be quenched. Nor will they—until presumably their work of destruction is done." There is no hope that the fire would go out or the worms would die—the wickeds' bodies and souls will be completely removed leaving them as 'an abhorrence to all flesh.'

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[120] Augustine, *City of God*, Book XXI, Chapter 11.
[121] Mark 9:44.
[122] Isa. 55:24.

The warnings of Mark 9 have Old Testament roots extending further than Isaiah 66. Jesus warns against sinning that would cause one to 'go to Hell,' 'be cast into Hell,' or 'cast into hellfire.' The Greek word is *Gehenna*. As explained previously, Gehenna refers to the Valley of the Sons of Hinnom, sometimes called Tophet. Jeremiah 19 explains what happened in Tophet originally and how God dealt with it. Israel had "filled [Tophet] with the blood of the innocents,"[123] and "built the high places of Baal, to burn their sons with fire for burnt offerings to Baal."[124] In response, Jeremiah recalls, "'therefore behold, the days are coming,' says the Lord, 'that this place shall no more be called Tophet or the Valley of the Son of Hinnom, but the Valley of Slaughter…'"[125] And again, "their corpses I will give as meat for the birds of the heaven and for the beasts of the earth,"[126] And finally, "Even so I will break this people and this city, as one breaks a potter's vessel, which cannot be made whole again; and they shall bury them in Tophet till there is no place to bury."[127] In addition, Isaiah also describes Tophet as a place of annihilation. Isaiah 30:33 says, "For Tophet was established of old, Yes, for the king it is prepared. He has made it deep and large; Its pyre is fire with much wood; The breath of the Lord, like a stream of brimstone, Kindles it."[128] *This* is Gehenna: The place that symbolizes the outworking of God's consuming wrath on sin. In Mark 9, Jesus is referencing this Old Testament location in His description of sinners being 'cast into Hell' and thus recalling the concepts of *destruction* and *death*—not eternal torment.

The story of the rich man and Lazarus found in Luke 16:19-31 is a favorite traditionalist passage. It is popularly used to defend the eternal torment view simply based on its vivid imagery of a Hell-like place. Importantly, the setting for this parable is not actually Hell. The

[123] Jer. 19:4.
[124] Jer. 19:5.
[125] Jer. 19:6.
[126] Jer. 19:7.
[127] Jer. 19:11.
[128] Isa. 30:33.

Greek text uses the word *Hades*, not *Gehenna.* As previously explained, *Hades* refers to the intermediate state in the Bible and *Gehenna* refers to the final judgment. Luke 16:19-31 is clearly a parable, for numerous reasons including the ability of the characters to communicate across enormous chasms and the fact that Lazarus sits on the 'bosom of Abraham.'[129]. In fact, the parable of the Rich man and Lazarus is a reworked version of a story commonly told in Israel.[130] This indicates Jesus not only did not intend this story to reveal details about the judgment of sinners, but did not even intend to tell His audience factual details about the intermediate state.

Even if taken literally, Luke 16:19-31 never states that the rich man is in *eternal* torment, even while in the intermediate state. Therefore, conditionalists may take this passage fully literally without contradicting their position on God's ultimate and final judgment. Finally, this parable has a clear point that is not directly related to the final destiny of sinners and culminates in the 'lesson' in verse 31, "If they do not hear Moses and the prophets, neither will they be persuaded though one rise from the dead."[131] The point here has nothing to do with the final state of the wicked nor even the intermediate state, but rather the unrepentant nature of those who did not listen to the prophets. The unrelated details, therefore, should not be the basis for an entire *doctrine*, especially when the rest of the Bible clearly *contradicts* that belief.

Daniel 12:2, sometimes used as a proof text by traditionalists, reads: "And many of those who sleep in the dust of the earth shall awake, Some to everlasting life, Some to shame and everlasting contempt." Traditionalists want this passage to mean that the wicked are ashamed while alive forever.[132] However, the text does not prove this and rather implies the opposite. God chose His wording carefully in this passage to be consistent with the rest of His Word. Some

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[129] Clark Pinnock, "The destruction of the Finally Impenitent," in *Rethinking Hell*, ed. Christopher M. Date (Eugene, Oregon: Wipf and Stock Publishers), 36.

[130] Joachim Jeremias, *Rediscovering the Parables* (New York: Scribner, 1966), 141, 145.

[131] Luke 16:31.

[132] Blanchard, *Whatever Happened to Hell?,* 145-146.

people will receive eternal *life*, heavily implying the opposite to be death. Notably, while the 'contempt' is stated to be everlasting, the 'shame' is *not*. Therefore, this verse fits perfectly well with the belief that the wicked are raised for a temporary time, receive judgment, and are ultimately deprived of life. During this period of time, the wicked feel shame. Later, after their complete destruction, the immortal righteous hold them in a state of contempt which never terminates.

The book of Revelation poses the most formidable challenge to conditionalists. Nonetheless, God gave mankind his *entire* word, not merely a book of prophecy containing often confusing symbolic imagery. In fact, Revelation has been described as a 'grand central station' of Biblical imagery and borrows heavily from Old Testament symbolism.[133] Utilizing the original sources of such imagery, and following the general exegetical principle of 'simpler and clearer passages should interpret more confusing ones,' conditionalism has a very consistent and reasonable interpretation of Revelation.[134]

Revelation 14:9-11 is perhaps the closest thing to an actual description of the traditional Hell that the Bible contains:

> Then a third angel followed them, saying with a loud voice, "If anyone worships the beast and his image, and receives his mark on his forehead or on his hand, he himself shall also drink of the wine of the wrath of God, which is poured out full strength into the cup of His indignation. He shall be tormented with fire and brimstone in the presence of the holy angels and in the presence of the Lamb. And the smoke of their torment ascends forever and ever; and they have no rest day or night, who worship the beast and his image, and whoever receives the mark of his name."[135]

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[133] John Miller, "When Hell Is Let Loose" (Feb. 2021).

[134] Christopher M. Date, "The Hermeneutics of Conditionalism: A Defense of the Interpretive Method of Edward Fudge," (Evangelical Quarterly, 2018), 84.

[135] Rev. 14:9-11.

Much evidence suggests Revelation 14 is metaphorical, not a literal account of coming events. Edward Fudge writes, "We need to recall we are not viewing a newsreel from the archives of the History Channel, but a highly symbolic vision…"[136] For example, few—if any—scholars suggest there will be an actual winepress God uses to crush the wicked. In fact, if literal, it would contradict this very account. If, according to traditionalist interpretation, verses 9-11 refer to eternal torment, then how can those same people be tormented *and* be crushed in a winepress? There is no reason to believe that even though the later verses of Revelation 14 are metaphorical, verses 9-11 are a literal account.

Even if this passage was literal, it speaks to a specific group of people alive at the time of Christ's coming. The judgment of all mankind comes later in the book of Revelation, and does not mention any scene of torture. In addition, Revelation 14 never states the torment of these beast-worshippers is actually forever; that must be implied from the smoke. This proposition cannot be implied when the Old Testament context is considered. The book of Revelation takes the phrase 'smoke rises forever' from the Old Testament. After the complete destruction of Sodom, Genesis 19:28 remarks, "Then he looked toward Sodom and Gomorrah, and toward all the land of the plain; and he saw, and behold, the smoke of the land which went up like the smoke of a furnace."[137] Edom also is destroyed, and Isaiah 34:10 comments, "It shall not be quenched night or day; Its smoke shall ascend forever. From generation to generation it shall lie waste; No one shall pass through it forever and ever."[138] The ever-rising smoke does not refer to eternal torment, but rather eternal annihilation as was experienced by Sodom and Edom. Finally, the book of Revelation further explains its own usage of 'smoke rising forever' several chapters later. Revelation 18 explains the fall of Babylon and in no unclear terms lays out its permanent

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[136] Fudge, *The Fire that Consumes*, 240.
[137] Gen. 19:28.
[138] Isa. 34:10.

desolation from fire. Following this, Revelation 19:3 comments, "Alleluia! Her smoke rises up forever and ever!"[139] Based on these previous usages of smoke imagery, the Bible does not intend readers to stew over implications about 'eternal fuel' for 'eternal smoke.' On the contrary, it defines its own terms. Smoke rising forever indicates permanent infamy and a final destruction that is never reversed.

Traditionalist advocates also point to the phrase "no rest night and day" as support for eternal torment. However, this statement is actually in the present tense, meaning it refers to the beast-worshippers' dread over the coming punishment, not their feelings during the punishment itself. Douglas Barry writes, "The 'no resting day or night' occurs while they are 'bowing' and 'worshiping' (present tense) the beast."[140] Even if the loss of rest described in this passage happened during torment, it is never stated to be eternal. Fudge explains, "Their suffering is not exclusively a 'daytime' activity, nor is it exclusively a 'nighttime' activity. There is no intermission in the suffering while it continues."[141] Thus, 'no rest day or night' tells readers nothing about the duration of God's enactment of justice.

Another passage that initially appears to support the eternal torment view is Revelation 20:10, which states: "The devil, who deceived them, was cast into the lake of fire and brimstone where the beast and the false prophet are. And they will be tormented day and night forever and ever."[142] Absent in this verse is any mention of sinful *humans* being tormented day and night. Many conditionalists also argue that the devil, beast, and false prophet's torment is an abstraction representing the conquest of evil and death. According to Fudge, "In the larger story-line of Revelation, the beast and false prophet represent persecuting civil government and its cohort,

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[139] Rev. 19:3.

[140] Douglas Barry, "Conditional Immortality: Biblical Proof of Annihilation in Hell," (March 13, 2013), 50.

[141] Edward W. Fudge, "The Final End of the Wicked," in *Rethinking Hell*, ed. Christopher M. Date (Eugene, Oregon: Wipf and Stock Publishers), 38.

[142] Rev. 20:10.

corrupt false religion."[143] This could easily be true, but the argument is not even necessary to disprove the traditionalist implications of Revelation 20:10. In order to make this verse apply to the wicked, the traditional view must argue that since the wicked are cast into the same fire as the devil, they must face the same fate. Such a logical conclusion is tenuous. Fire often acts upon different classes of things differently. For example, metal can last in fire without melting, but wood burns up. Beyond the argument's irrationality, the Bible itself rebuts it just one chapter later. Revelation 21:8 says, "[The wicked] shall have their part in the lake which burns with fire and brimstone, which is the second death."[144] The wicked enter the fire and are killed.

To avoid the implications of this, the traditional view falsely interprets this phrase found in Revelation 21:8. The verse says the wicked go to the lake of fire, "which is the second death."[145] Summarized by Fudge, "Traditionalist authors always read the equation the other direction, *as if* it said "the second death" (indefinite) is "the lake of fire" (clear). In fact, however, John says that "the lake of fire" (his symbol) is "the second death" (a clearer reality)."[146] Within biblical prophecy, God explains an indeterminate *symbol* with a more concrete *reality*. Daniel 7:17 says, "Those great beasts, which are four, are four kings which arise out of the earth."[147] Daniel 8:20-21 says, "The ram which you saw, having the two horns—they are the kings of Media and Persia. And the male goat is the kingdom of Greece. The large horn that is between its eyes is the first king."[148] Even the book of Revelation uses this literary device before chapter 21. Revelation 4:5, for example, says, "...Seven lamps of fire were burning before the throne, which are the seven Spirits of God."[149] In each case, the symbol comes first and the author then notes a

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[143] Edward William Fudge, *The Fire that Consumes*, 247.
[144] Rev. 21:8.
[145] Rev. 21:8.
[146] Fudge, 249.
[147] Dan. 7:17.
[148] Dan. 8:20-21.
[149] Rev. 4:5.

clearer reality it represents. It remains unclear, then, how the traditional view can hold that *the second death* represents the *lake of fire*, rather than letting the natural linguistic structure determine that the *lake of fire* represents *the second death*. However, even without a proper understanding of symbolism, Revelation 21:8 never claims that humans will be *alive forever* in the lake of fire. The central detail required to prove the eternal torment view is not found in this text.

Thus, the passages supposedly supporting traditionalism melt away. In order to make any of these verses about eternal torment, one must ignore the linguistic structure and Old Testament background. It seems traditionalist interpretations of these texts depend on presupposed concepts of the immortal soul inherited from Greek philosophy, not God's revelation. However, when efforts are made to understand the texts within the light of context and the rest of Scripture, they are shown to be, at worst, inapplicable to the debate and, at best, support for conditional immortality.

Life in Christ Alone

Dr. Al Mohler claimed in a 2014 episode of *The Briefing*, "The problem with the argument of the conditionalist is that they're picking and choosing Scriptures and they're running in the face of the traditional Christian understanding based upon the Bible…when it comes to the depictions of Hell in Scripture, you're not looking at any promise of conditional immortality."[150] Traditionalists believe Scripture backs their side and disputes conditional immortality.

In reality, the Bible teaches that the *righteous* inherit eternal life, and *only* the righteous. Conditional immortality is a carefully chosen name for the doctrine it supports. In general, a

[150] Albert Mohler, "The Briefing 10-15-14," October 15, 2014 in *The Briefing*, podcast transcript, https://albertmohler.com/2014/10/15/the-briefing-10-15-14.

condition means a 'criteria' that must be met to get some 'reward.' In this case, the 'reward' is immortality, and the 'condition' is belief in Christ. This Biblical message stands in contrast to universal immortality supported by most traditionalists and universalists. The central conditionalist claim is supported throughout the Bible, especially as it relates to the gospel message.

Eternal life is a gift given on a set condition. Evidence for this is found in the most famous Bible verse: John 3:16. "For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life."[151] The one who believes in Jesus, the condition, receives eternal life, immortality. The context of John 3:16 strengthens its message. In John 3:14-15, Jesus compares himself to the bronze serpent from the book of Numbers. In that Old Testament narrative, the people were attacked by serpents and headed toward death. The condition for saving their life is looking upon the bronze serpent, an act requiring faith. By nature, mankind is headed toward perishing. John 3:18 explains, "He who believes in Him is not condemned; but he who does not believe is condemned already, because he has not believed in the name of the only begotten Son of God."[152] Therefore, the previous and subsequent verses to John 3:16 demonstrate that humans are *by nature* heading toward death, but by *intervention* saved to life.

Jesus frequently states the same central principle of conditional immortality. In Luke 9:24-25 He says, "...whoever desires to save his life will lose it, but whoever loses his life for My sake will save it. For what profit is it to a man if he gains the whole world, and is himself destroyed or lost?"[153] The condition: losing one's life for Christ's sake. The reward: truly saving one's life. Matthew 7:13-14 says: "Enter by the narrow gate; for wide is the gate and broad is the

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[151] John 3:16.
[152] John 3:18.
[153] Luke 9:24-25.

way that leads to destruction, and there are many who go in by it. Because narrow is the gate and difficult is the way which leads to life, and there are few who find it."[154] The condition: entering the narrow gate. The reward: life. Luke 20:35-36 says: "...those who are counted worthy to attain that age, and the resurrection from the dead, neither marry nor are given in marriage; nor can they die anymore, for they are equal to the angels and are sons of God, being sons of the resurrection."[155] The condition: being counted worthy. The reward: raised from the dead never to die again. John 6:51 says: "I am the living bread which came down from heaven. If anyone eats of this bread, he will live forever; and the bread that I shall give is My flesh, which I shall give for the life of the world."[156] The condition: 'eating' the bread of life. The reward: living forever. John 10:27-28 says, "My sheep hear My voice, and I know them, and they follow Me. And I give them eternal life, and they shall never perish; neither shall anyone snatch them out of My hand."[157] The condition: being the Lord's sheep. The reward: eternal life.

Adherents of the traditional view may question the framing of these words. Perhaps Jesus is merely referring to earthly life when he says the unsaved perish, when in reality their *souls* go on to eternal life. Aside from the text never indicating this, such speculation fails in several ways. First, eternal life and perishing are contrasted as the two options for humans on this earth. Second, Christians *also* die, so Jesus would be making a non-point. Third, if Christians accept *eternal life* as the final state of *the righteous*, then *eternal death* is likewise the final state of *the wicked*. Finally, if the traditional doctrine were true, Jesus would be leaving out a critical component of his argument. We know God's character is complete truth, and he provides

[154] Matt. 7:13-14.
[155] Luke 20:35-36.
[156] John 6:51.
[157] John 10:27-28.

warnings to men of the consequences awaiting them. It would not comport with God's character to omit this crucial detail in his warnings spoken to the lost then, and now recorded in His Word.

Imagery Revisited

Evangelical Christians often approach Scripture assuming the eternal torment view is taught. This causes them to falsely draw conclusions from certain biblical phrases and imagery. Among these are fire, worms, weeping, and gnashing of teeth.

Fire normally destroys things—although the destructive process may include pain. Universal human experience dictates this proposition, but the Bible teaches it as well. Jesus explains in Matthew 3:12, "His winnowing fan is in His hand, and He will thoroughly clean out His threshing floor, and gather His wheat into the barn; but He will burn up the chaff with unquenchable fire."[158] The fire of God's judgment, which cannot be put out, will completely burn up the wicked. So in other places, when the Bible says God will 'cast the wicked into fire' or 'inflict fire upon them' et. cetera, the most natural interpretation would be that He is *consuming them* with fire, not *torturing them* for an extended time. In support of that, Malachi 4:1-3 says, "For behold, the day is coming, burning like an oven, when all the arrogant and all evildoers will be stubble. The day that is coming shall set them ablaze, says the Lord of hosts, so that it will leave them neither root nor branch. But for you who fear my name . . . you shall tread down the wicked, for they will be ashes under the soles of your feet, on the day when I act, says the Lord of hosts."[159] Fire may cause pain and suffering, but this does not invalidate the other central characteristic of fire: It destroys.

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[158] Matt. 3:12.
[159] Mal. 4:1-3.

Corollary to this idea of fire as destructive in nature is the concept of 'unquenchable fire.' The eternal torment view believes unquenchable fire means endless fire that never goes out. Mentioned earlier was Jesus's usage of unquenchable fire to refer to the unstoppable consumption of 'the chaff'—not to everlasting burning. Beyond this, traditionalists also forget the Old Testament context of imagery. 'Unquenchable' does not mean 'ever-burning' according to Isaiah. Isaiah 1:31 says, "The strong shall be as tinder, And the work of it as a spark; Both will burn together, And no one shall quench them."[160] 'Unquenchable fire' means fire that is not able to be put out. Mark 9:42-48 is the main chapter using the phrase unquenchable fire. Jesus quotes Isaiah 66, which states "their fire is not quenched."[161] This statement does not imply everlasting burning. It means the fire can't be put out by any outside force.

Isaiah 66 also includes a reference to 'undying worms.' The traditionalist believes the worms are actively tormenting humans, never perishing. On the face of it, this idea is a little exaggerated. Worms are not primarily agents of torment—even if certain parasites can function that way. More commonly, worms decompose dead things. Regardless, within the immediate context, this interpretation is directly contradicted. Isaiah 66 builds up to the scene of worms with verse 16 saying, "For by fire and by His sword, The Lord will judge all flesh; And the slain of the Lord shall be many,"[162] and verse 17, "'Those who sanctify themselves and purify themselves, To go to the gardens, After an idol in the midst, Eating swine's flesh and the abomination and the mouse, Shall be consumed together,' says the Lord."[163] Following these declarations of death and annihilation, Isaiah 66:24 reads, "And they shall go forth and look, Upon the corpses of the men, Who have transgressed against Me. For their worm does not die,

[160] Isa. 1:31.
[161] Isa 66:24.
[162] Isa. 66:16.
[163] Isa. 66:17.

And their fire is not quenched. They shall be an abhorrence to all flesh."[164] The picture in Isaiah has nothing to do with torture, and everything to do with destruction and disrepute. Jesus quotes this text in Mark 9, but eternal torment advocates never review the original source. Edward Fudge summarizes, "Traditionalists have ignored Isaiah's picture, then interpreted Jesus as though his language had no biblical precedent." [165]

Weeping and gnashing of teeth indicate torture to the traditionalist. Such language is attributed to the judgment of the wicked in Matthew 8:12, Matthew 13:42, Matthew 13:50, Matthew 22:13, Matthew 24:51, Matthew 25:30, and Luke 13:28. But do these actions necessarily indicate torment? Weeping may be done by someone in sadness or distress. Gnashing of teeth could be done in rage, not pain. Both of these interpretations of the imagery would still indicate suffering, but not the kind of fiery torture chamber the traditional view wishes to support. In fact, these proposed renderings of weeping and gnashing of teeth are found elsewhere in scripture. David weeps when he leaves his friend Jonathan in 1 Samuel 20:41. In John 11:35, Jesus wept over the death of his friend Lazarus. Jesus also wept over the city of Jerusalem in Luke 19:41. In each of these cases, weeping is related to loss, not immediate pain. Teeth gnashing is also found in Acts 7:54, Job 16:9, and Lamentations 2:16. In each of these cases, wrath and anger is the cause, not pain.

Such interpretations of the phrase 'weeping and gnashing of teeth' are also supported within the context of some of the source texts. For example, Matthew 8:12 says, "But the sons of the kingdom will be cast out into outer darkness. There will be weeping and gnashing of teeth."[166] Outer darkness does not indicate any source of pain. Rather, the key focus is *exclusion*. The sons of the kingdom lose their special place with God. To the same effect, Luke 13:28 says,

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[164] Isa. 66:24.
[165] Fudge, "The Final End of the Wicked," 36.
[166] Matt. 8:12.

"There will be weeping and gnashing of teeth, when you see Abraham and Isaac and Jacob and all the prophets in the kingdom of God, and yourselves thrust out."[167] Logically, such a loss would invoke tears of sadness and anger.

Understanding the true meaning of Biblical imagery removes false support claimed for the traditional view. The intent in pointing out these misconceptions is not to suggest there is *no pain* involved in God's judgment. Rather, this demonstrates that Hell is not for *endless* pain but rather *endless destruction.* Hell is not a torture chamber.

The Premise of Atonement

God's old covenant system of law demonstrates that sin's penalty is destruction. With the advent of the new covenant, this fact remains the same but with hope for ultimately overcoming death.

The book of Leviticus describes the sacrificial system. An animal needed to die to cover over the sins of an Israelite. Certainly the death of an animal sacrifice *involved* pain but never does God mandate an animal receive torment to cleanse sin. Interestingly, the sin offering was commanded to be completely burned to ashes. Leviticus 4:12, "the whole bull [the priest] shall carry outside the camp to a clean place, where the ashes are poured out, and burn it on wood with fire; where the ashes are poured out it shall be burned."[168] Other sacrifices do not involve animal death or are not burned to ashes. The burnt offering, for example, created "a sweet aroma to the Lord."[169] This indicates God's posture toward sin: complete annihilation of the sinful person that reduces to ashes.

The book of Hebrews describes the relationship of the new covenant to the old covenant. The new covenant abolishes the old covenant. Hebrews 6:18-19 says, "For on the one hand there

[167] Luke 13:28.
[168] Lev. 4:12.
[169] Lev. 1:9.

is an annulling of the former commandment because of its weakness and unprofitableness, for the law made nothing perfect; on the other hand, there is the bringing in of a better hope, through which we draw near to God."[170] Hebrews 9 explains that the new covenant continues through the sacrifice and leadership of Jesus.

> But Christ came as High Priest of the good things to come, with the greater and more perfect tabernacle not made with hands, that is, not of this creation. Not with the blood of goats and calves, but with His own blood He entered the Most Holy Place once for all, having obtained eternal redemption. For if the blood of bulls and goats and the ashes of a heifer, sprinkling the unclean, sanctifies for the purifying of the flesh, how much more shall the blood of Christ, who through the eternal Spirit offered Himself without spot to God, cleanse your conscience from dead works to serve the living God? And for this reason He is the Mediator of the new covenant, by means of death, for the redemption of the transgressions under the first covenant, that those who are called may receive the promise of the eternal inheritance.[171]

The book of Hebrews compares Jesus to a sacrifice. In fact, he is the *perfect* sacrifice. He 'offered Himself without spot to God,' and 'is the Mediator of the new covenant by means of death.' God atones for mankind's punishment through the death of His Son. If Christ took on the punishment man deserved, and Christ's punishment was death, then the punishment man originally deserved was death.

Other verses support this idea as well. 1 John 3:16 says, "By this we know love, because He laid down His life for us. And we also ought to lay down our lives for the brethren." 1 Peter 2:24 says, " who Himself bore our sins in His own body on the tree, that we, having died to sins, might live for righteousness—by whose stripes you were healed." In Matthew 20:28, Jesus says, "...the Son of Man did not come to be served, but to serve, and to give His life a ransom for many." Romans 5:6-11 puts this whole concept very potently.

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[170] Heb. 6:18-19.
[171] Heb. 9:11-15.

> For when we were still without strength, in due time Christ died for the ungodly. For scarcely for a righteous man will one die; yet perhaps for a good man someone would even dare to die. But God demonstrates His own love toward us, in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us. Much more then, having now been justified by His blood, we shall be saved from wrath through Him. For if when we were enemies we were reconciled to God through the death of His Son, much more, having been reconciled, we shall be saved by His life. And not only that, but we also rejoice in God through our Lord Jesus Christ, through whom we have now received the reconciliation.[172]

First Paul says that Christ *died* for the ungodly—not suffered eternal torment; Christ's *death* atones. Second, Christ's death justifies believers in God's eyes. All are offered this grace, but it must be accepted. Third, Christ's atoning death saves believers from *wrath*. Fourth, Christ's resurrection leads to ultimate reconciliation with God.

Only the saved who accept the atonement of Christ are able to receive the eternal inheritance waiting for them in Heaven. Eternal life is only to those who are justified and made righteous—cleansed from sin. Unbelievers will face the death they deserve—a death that could have been avoided by accepting *Christ's* death in their stead.

Interpretative Pitfalls

Traditionalism's most supported argument against annihilationism is found in their exegesis of Biblical words. They deny that the words 'destroy,' 'perish,' 'consumed,' 'cut off,' 'burned up,' et cetera truly refer to annihilation. The point is a good one, but fails to actually disprove a conditionalist interpretation within the specific context of final judgment.

In his book, *The doctrine of eternal punishment*, Harry Buis writes, "The very same words which the annihilationists claim can only mean complete cessation of existence are in fact

[172] Rom. 5:6-11.

used in the Scriptures themselves to mean something very different than annihilation."[173] He then proceeds to attack certain words one by one. To debunk the word 'perish', Buis cites Isaiah 57:1, which uses the word 'perish' of the *righteous*, not the wicked.[174] "The righteous perishes, And no man takes it to heart;" Annihilationists do not deny that the righteous may die while on earth. However, their death is distinct from the death of the wicked. The text of Isaiah 57 continues, saying that when the righteous man dies, "He shall enter into peace; They shall rest in their beds, Each one walking in his uprightness."[175] We know from the rest of Scripture that the righteous will live again, receiving immortality. So the word 'perish' still refers to death, but is then clarified *within the text* to refer not to the never-ending non-existence the wicked undergo, but rather to peace ending in renewed life. So Buis has not yet shown the word 'perish' cannot refer to annihilation.

Buis continues, citing 1 Samuel 9:3 and 9:20.[176] These verses state that the donkeys of Kish, Saul's father, were lost and uses the word 'perish.' A word does not always have to mean the same exact thing in every use case. This is a case *not talking about the final state of the lost*. In fact, 'Perish' referring to death in some contexts and only being 'lost' in others reveals there is a deep *similarity* between a lost possession and a dead person. When Kish's donkeys were lost, he could not see them; They had gone out of his perception, ownership, and knowledge of location. Therefore this usage of perish as 'lost'—far from disproving the conditionalist interpretation of death—strengthens it by revealing that perishing is similar to being lost. Still, the fact that one text uses perish to mean being 'lost' does not prove that other texts cannot use the same word in a different sense.

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[173] Harry Buis, *The Doctrine of Eternal Punishment* (Philadelphia, Pennsylvania: Presbyterian and Reformed Publishing Company, 1957), 124.

[174] Buis, *The Doctrine of Eternal Punishment*, 124.

[175] Isa. 57:2.

[176] Buis, *The Doctrine of Eternal Punishment*, 124.

In rebutting the word 'destroy,' Buis entirely misses the point. He cites three verses that supposedly disprove destruction having its intended meaning.[177] The first is Job 19:10, "He breaks me down on every side, And I am gone; My hope He has uprooted like a tree." Buis misses the distinction between destruction of possessions—including health and status—and destruction of the soul. Destruction *always* means annihilation, but context clarifies what is being annihilated. Job is a poetic book. Thus, to say Job was 'broken down on every side' is a poetic way of stating his possessions, health, and status were removed. Job 19:19-20 justifies this interpretation saying, "All my close friends abhor me, And those whom I love have turned against me. My bone clings to my skin and to my flesh…"[178] Besides, Job 19 is a poor choice of Scripture to support eternal torment. Job 19:25-29 excellently demonstrates the truth of conditional immortality:

> For I know that my Redeemer lives,
> And He shall stand at last on the earth;
> And after my skin is destroyed, this I know,
> That in my flesh I shall see God,
> …If you should say, 'How shall we persecute him?'—
> Since the root of the matter is found in me,
> Be afraid of the sword for yourselves;
> For wrath brings the punishment of the sword,
> That you may know there is a judgment.[179]

Thus, the very passage supposedly 'disproving' destruction as annihilation supports the central claim of conditional immortality: only the righteous will remain in God's presence. The unrighteous will face 'the sword' and 'judgment'—not eternal torment.

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[177] Buis, *The Doctrine of Eternal Punishment*, 125.
[178] Job 19:19-20.
[179] Job 19:25-26, 28-29.

Other traditionalist authors repeat Buis's errors. Robert A. Moray cites Numbers 21:19, where the people of Israel are enslaved.[180] This is referred to as 'destruction.' The annihilated elements are the sovereignty, freedom, and prosperity of the nation of Israel. John Blanchard cites Jeremiah 9:12,[181] which says "Why does the land perish and burn up like a wilderness, so that no one can pass through?" In addition, he cites Jeremiah 48:8 which makes a similar statement about Moab. Blanchard believes this disproves destruction as annihilation. He misses the nuance as to *what is being annihilated*. Conditionalism does not teach that annihilation is the removal of every subatomic element within an object. The word refers to the removal of some object, quality, or person. When 'the land perishes', the quality of general health and prosperity is being annihilated. Were the traditionalist interpretation of 'destruction as misery' true, the land must constantly burn without ever ceasing. This is simply not the image given in Jeremiah 9:12.

The next verse cited by Buis to disprove 'destruction' proof texts is Hosea 13:9. It states, "O Israel, you are destroyed, But your help is from Me."[182] Buis misses the distinction between *final* annihilation and *temporary* annihilation. Conditionalism affirms that Israel was indeed destroyed during some times of history, but was redeemed from that state of ruin. In addition, annihilation does not mean there are no remains of what formerly was—ashes remain after fire. Instead, annihilation means the functionality of an object is removed. In this case, Israel as a nation had lost its wealth, glory, and many of its members. So to say Israel was temporarily destroyed is perfectly logical within the context of annihilation—loss of functionality. The words immediately after Hosea 13:9 say, "I will ransom them from the power of the grave; I will redeem them from death." This cycle of temporary destruction followed by redemption is a

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[180] Robert A. Morey, *Death and the afterlife* (Minneapolis, Minn: Bethany House, 1984), 109.
[181] Blanchard, *Whatever Happened to Hell?*, 234.
[182] Hos. 13:9.

repeated concept in the Old Testament. Therefore, 'destruction' in this context does indeed mean 'annihilation,' but not in the final sense.

Exodus 10:7 is the final verse Buis cites. It says, "Then Pharaoh's servants said to him, 'How long shall this man be a snare to us? Let the men go, that they may serve the Lord their God. Do you not yet know that Egypt is destroyed?'" Within context, Egypt had been ravaged by seven plagues. Many had died and much wealth had been lost. Thus, to say Egypt is destroyed reflects an aspect of annihilation. In this case, some members of Egypt, their possessions, and their wealth are eliminated. Thus, the Exodus 10:7 usage of the word 'destruction' provides insight into the *general* usage of the term but differs from the *specific* usage of the term when applied to the final state of the unrighteous.

Scripture can use the same word for different contexts. Notice that the verses above never speak to the *final state* of the wicked. So what does the Bible mean by 'destroy' when speaking of the end of sinners? The wicked are destroyed in a sense *beyond* simply possessions or health. Revelation 21:8 says the wicked enter the "second death."[183] This means they experience a death *after* the normal one experienced by all mankind. The first death removes all movement and leaves a rotting corpse; The second death is analogous to the first according to Revelation. 2 Peter 2:12 says the unrighteous "are like unreasoning animals, creatures of instinct, born only to be caught and destroyed, and like animals they too will perish."[184] Unless traditionalists would like to say *animals* are tortured forever, this text contradicts the eternal torment definition of 'perish' and 'destroyed.' Remember the narratives of the flood and Sodom? The wicked men of the earth and the wicked men of Sodom and Gomorrah were annihilated by God. While they still face an ultimate judgment in the final day,[185] their stories are utilized in three places within the

[183] Rev. 21:8.
[184] 2 Peter 2:12, NIV.
[185] Matt. 10:15.

New Testament each to describe how God will operate on judgment day. God left these stories with us for a reason; He demonstrates the meaning and intent behind the words 'perish' and 'destruction.' John 3:16 and many other verses which support a conditional promise of life only for the righteous also support the idea of annihilation for the wicked; If 'eternal life' is given to believers, the natural opposite of this is 'eternal death.' Jesus, being a master of the Old Testament, used the word 'perish,'—originally found in the Torah, Psalms, and major prophets—to convey the final fate of the unsaved. So clearly, annihilation is in view when the words 'perish' or 'destroy' are applied to the final state of the lost. The fact that *other* contexts use the same words to mean something slightly different does not disprove the *specific* application of these words to the final state.

Traditionalists Fire Back

Now comes a series of philosophical and theological challenges levied at the conditionalist position. Both historical and contemporary traditionalists have presented arguments and conundrums in an attempt to discredit or contradict the view.

Saint Augustine wrote in the *City of God*, "To say that life eternal shall be endless, [but that] punishment eternal shall come to an end is the height of absurdity."[186] Conditionalists agree: The punishment God inflicts on the wicked never shall end. Never will the unredeemed be raised to life again or brought back. Conditionalists disagree that the punishment is endless torture. God will punish the wicked with everlasting destruction apart from God's presence.[187] Augustine's point is a good response to universalism, but does not account for the alternative of eternal *death*, not eternal *torment*.

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[186] Augustine, *City of God*, Book XXI chapter 23.
[187] 2 Thess. 1:9.

C.S. Lewis, a respected Christian thinker, argues against annihilation in *The Problem of Pain*. He admits, "There is no doctrine which I would more willingly remove from Christianity than this, if it lay in my power. But it has the full support of Scripture and, specially, of Our Lord's own words; it has always been held by Christendom; and it has the support of reason. If a game is played, it must be possible to lose it."[188] Lewis is commendable for his honesty in supporting what he believes scripture says. Regardless, it has been demonstrated the wealth of biblical support for conditional immortality and how little remains for the eternal torment view. As seen earlier, Lewis falsely believes the traditional view has always been held by Christendom, and would have done well to more thoroughly examine the church fathers. As regards the final statement, conditionalists wholeheartedly agree that God's Word teaches a 'lose-state.' The chief disagreement centers upon what the punishment for sin entails. The Bible is clear that *destruction* is the punishment, not *eternal torment*.

Lewis next presents an argument for the immortal soul. He writes,

> People often talk as if the "annihilation" of a soul were intrinsically possible. In all our experience, however, the destruction of one thing means the emergence of something else. Burn a log, and you have gases, heat and ash. To have been a log means now being diose three things. If soul can be destroyed, must there not be a state of having been a human soul? And is not that, perhaps, the state which is equally well described as torment, destruction, and privation?[189]

C.S. Lewis is correct in reminding his readers of a central principle of physics—that matter is not created or destroyed. Beyond that, Lewis's reasoning for the immortal soul is flimsy. Dead bodies still 'exist' in terms of the molecules that made up the former living person, but no one thinks dead bodies are conscious. Despite their remains, dead men are still considered 'killed, perished,

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[188] C.S. Lewis, *The Problem Of Pain*, 106.
[189] C.S. Lewis, *The Problem of Pain*, 113.

or destroyed.' If a log is burned, gas, heat, and ashes may still exist, but the essential nature of the wood is gone. The remains of the log could not be used for any normal function of wood. Likewise, the souls and bodies of the wicked are destroyed in that they no longer function as a soul and body: they have no movement, no breath, no talking, no feeling, no thinking, and no consciousness. Lewis provides no reason why 'destruction of a soul' should entail continuous existence as a conscious being experiencing pain forever, rather than the cessation of experience supported by common sense.

John Piper writes, "The abandonment of this biblical truth is following the pattern of how other unpopular biblical teachings are being abandoned…Personal emotions and desires combine with speculative reasonings about general ideas, and they take precedence over specific biblical texts and teachings."[190] The audience would like to know what these other abandoned doctrines are, who is abandoning them, and why. Piper is attempting to accuse conditionalism of ignoring or disagreeing with Scripture, when in reality conditionalism is going *back* to scripture, reading it, and drawing reasonable conclusions. Take a moment to look back on the Bible passages, narratives, and principles presented in this thesis. Decide for yourself whether eternal torment or destruction better matches the Bible's text and teaching. Aside from the false assumptions, Piper's argument that the conditional view is false because it 'weakens' the historical position could equally be used to argue that the modern *traditional* view is false. Evangelicals today, following the example of C.S. Lewis, have drastically toned down the vivid imagery of torture used historically.[191] A view is not correct simply because it is less popular, inconsistent with God's revealed character, and more emotionally destructive.

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[190] John Piper, "The Echo and Insufficiency of Hell, Part 1." (June 4, 1992).
[191] Fudge, *The Fire that Consumes*, 360.

More recently, John Piper commented online, "Annihilation is what the unrepentant want, not what they dread. It would be a reward, not a punishment. Non-consciousness knows no loss."[192] While a clever argument, thinking on it for a moment reveals the absurdity. Piper says death "is a reward, not a punishment." No one considers non-existence a beneficial thing. Mankind universally fears death. Furthermore, according to Piper's standard, being murdered would not be evil, and being executed for a crime would not be a punishment.[193] No justice system agrees with Piper's philosophical construct, least of all God, who proclaims that "the wages of sin is death."[194]

Steve Johnstone presents his opinion on the case for conditional immortality when he writes, "Much of annihilationism is motivated by emotional difficulties in trying to reconcile the love and justice of God with eternal punishment."[195] Alas, the claim that 'much of annihilationism' is motivated only by emotion is not quantified nor substantiated. Many if not most evangelical conditionalists are motivated by what Scripture actually says. John Stott writes, "Emotionally, I find the concept [of eternal conscious torment] intolerable…But our emotions are a fluctuating, unreliable guide to truth and must not be exalted to the place of supreme authority in determining it . . . my question must be—and is—not what does my heart tell me, but what does God's word say?"[196] Following suit, Edward Fudge sums up the case for conditional immortality in Chapter 35 of the *Fire that Consumes*, "One issue alone divides traditionalists and conditionalists: Does Scripture teach that God will make the wicked immortal, to suffer unending conscious torment in hell? Or does the Bible teach that the wicked will finally

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[192] Dr Glenn Andrew Peoples, Right Reason, "So long, John Piper." (Jan. 2015).
[193] Peoples, "So long, John Piper."
[194] Romans 6:23.
[195] Steve Johnstone, "The eternality of Hell - a refutation of annihilationism," (Dec. 2013).
[196] David L. Edwards and John R. W. Stott, Evangelical Essentials: A Liberal-Evangelical Dialogue (Downers Grove: InterVarsity, 1988), 314-315.

and truly die, perish, and become extinct forever…?"[197] Emotional difficulties, theological questions, and consideration of God's character have their place in this debate, of course, but Scripture holds the chief authority. Besides, when a conditionalist mentions secondary, emotion-based points, this is usually a response to counter the incredibly severe and unreasonable traditional doctrine.

Timothy Keller stated online, "Unless you believe in Hell, you will never know how much Jesus loves you."[198] Again, the argument crumbles when conditionalists point out how they *also* believe in a serious punishment for sin, one which Jesus had to die to remove. Based on all the Scriptures read so far, that punishment is final death. There is no basis to say that punishment *must be eternal torment*, or 'Jesus does not really love humans'. 1 John 3:16 says, " By this we know love, because He laid down His life for us." Jesus' atoning *death* reveals His great love for us, not salvation from eternal torment in Hell.

The traditionalist thinker has one final argument. This theological and philosophical justification for eternal torment in Hell is the traditional view's strongest layer of defense, the crowning jewel, and the final solution to the conundrum of reconciling eternal torment with God's character. Put in a single sentence, "God's infinite justice demands infinite restitution for offense against His infinite dignity."[199] Similar iterations of this argument seek to justify why torment ought to continue infinitely. Numerous traditionalists have utilized this to explain to inquirers why eternal torment in Hell is necessary. Alan Gomes writes,

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[197] Fudge, 372.

[198] Peter Grice, Rethinking Hell, "Death Or Eternal Suffering—Which One Reveals How Much Jesus Loves You? (A Response To Timothy Keller)" (May 2018).

[199] Christopher Ray, "A Lukewarm Case For Eternal Torment: Responding To J. Warner Wallace." Rethinking Hell (2017).

> The nature of the object against which the sin is committed, as well as the nature of the sin itself, must be taken into account when determining the degree of heinousness… Torturing an animal is a crime, but torturing a human being is an even greater crime, worthy of greater punishment. …How much more serious, then, is even the slightest offense against an absolutely holy God, who is worthy of our complete and perpetual allegiance? …It is the annihilationist's theory that is morally flawed. Their God is not truly holy, for he does not demand that sin receive its due.[200]

Gomes makes a good argument but does not resolve the central question. Traditionalists and annihilationists fully agree that God's punishment on sin is infinite. The question is not *whether* God punishes sin with eternal punishment, but *what* that punishment entails. In fact, the conditionalist can take Gomes's argument a step further. He says "the nature of the object against which the sin is committed and the nature of the sin itself must be taken into account" but the conditionalist may add that 'the nature of the person who committed the sin' must *also* be taken into account. People are created as fragile beings with many flaws and inabilities. Should God not consider the limited nature of one who committed sin in his calculation of their punishment? A disabled teenager dies from cancer without ever hearing the gospel—must God inflict torment on their soul for all eternity? Does Gomes honestly hold that this would be justice? The traditionalist's response to this objection that God promises 'eternal punishment' on the unsaved has already been dealt with. Both the traditionalist and conditionalist agree God visits an *eternal* punishment on the wicked, but the conditionalist's version of that eternal punishment is far more consistent with the rest of Scripture, God's character, and natural intuition of what is just or not. In the end, the annihilationist position *does* believe God justly punishes sin, but that this retribution is *reasonable* and in accordance with Scripture's overall message.

Many other traditionalists make a similar point to Gomes. Shedd writes, "The guilt incurred yesterday is a standing and endless fact. What, therefore, guilt legitimates this instant, it

[200] Gomes, "Evangelicals and the Annihilation of Hell Part Two," 2-3.

legitimates every instant, and forever."[201] Yes, the punishment for sin continues on forever. That punishment is death. The guilt of sin is never removed. However, the traditional view fails to consider the key distinction between the *administration* of punishment, and the continuance of that punishment as an effect. The *enacting* of punishment on sin is temporary. If a criminal is given the death penalty, their punishment is received in a single moment, but the result—their absence from the world—continues indefinitely. God's administration of punishment follows this pattern. Psalm 78:8 says, "For in the hand of the LORD there is a cup, And the wine is red; It is fully mixed, and He pours it out; Surely its dregs shall all the wicked of the earth drain and drink down."[202] God's wrath is a *cup*, not an eternal stream. Ezekiel 5 is a very instructive passage for this purpose. The Lord God says to Jerusalem,

> One-third of you shall die of the pestilence, and be consumed with famine in your midst; and one-third shall fall by the sword all around you; and I will scatter another third to all the winds, and I will draw out a sword after them.
>
> 'Thus shall My anger be spent, and I will cause My fury to rest upon them, and I will be avenged; and they shall know that I, the Lord, have spoken it in My zeal, when I have spent My fury upon them. Moreover I will make you a waste and a reproach among the nations that are all around you, in the sight of all who pass by.[203]

It is clear from Ezekiel 15 that God exhibits fury and wrath while *enacting* judgment, but afterward, His anger is spent. None of this removes the lasting consequences of punishment. Jerusalem's ruin was temporary, but the final judgment will see the wicked destroyed by *eternal* fire that leaves no hope of restitution.

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[201] Shedd, *The Doctrine of Endless Punishment*, 129.
[202] Ps. 78:8.
[203] Ezek. 5:12-15.

Thomas Aquinas, an established and respected theologian, responded to objections against the traditional interpretation of eternal punishment. In the *Summa Theologica*, he writes,

> It would be inconsistent with Divine justice for the sinner to be brought to nothing absolutely, because this would be incompatible with the perpetuity of punishment that Divine justice requires, as stated above (A[3]).[204]

A sinner brought to nothing *would* be a perpetual punishment since their non-existent state would continue without end. Aquinas writes himself within the cited article that death *would* be a punishment—one that represents God's perpetual punishment on sin.

> Punishment is proportionate to sin in point of severity, both in Divine and in human judgments. …For the fact that adultery or murder is committed in a moment does not call for a momentary punishment: in fact they are punished sometimes by imprisonment or banishment for life—sometimes even by death; wherein account is not taken of the time occupied in killing, but rather of the expediency of removing the murderer from the fellowship of the living, so that this punishment, in its own way, represents the eternity of punishment inflicted by God.[205]

If Aquinas uses *death* as an example of a punishment, then he no longer has a basis to say God could not equally use *perpetual* death as sin's punishment. He believes this only 'represents' God's justice on sin, but the Bible clarifies that death *is* God's punishment. As previously cited, Romans 6:23 says, "The wages of sin is death."[206] 2 Thessalonians 1:9 says those who do not obey the gospel of Christ "shall be punished with everlasting destruction from the presence of the Lord and from the glory of His power."[207] Therefore, the justification offered by Aquinas—and many other traditionalist advocates—falls short in disproving eternal *destruction* as the true punishment for sin and fails to support why eternal *torment* is uniquely required.

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[204] Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologica* (1270), 1308.
[205] Aquinas, *Summa Theologica*, 1307.
[206] Rom. 6:23.
[207] 2 Thess. 1:9.

As a whole, the eternal torment perspective fails to provide adequate justification for continuing to believe their position instead of adopting conditionalism. This was seen through the generally poor argumentation against conditionalism including character attacks, misunderstandings of eternal punishment, and appeals to a faulty understanding of justice.

Universalist Proofs Refuted

Universalism argues that God will eventually redeem the lost through the purifying flames of Hell. Already, the many Scriptures read debunk this claim: if sin earns an eternal death, then there can be no end to that death. The arguments of universalists are still worth pondering, especially as they deepen the already strong connections of Scripture in favor of conditional immortality.

Revelation 20:12-15 reveals many details about the future day of judgment:

> And I saw the dead, small and great, standing before God, and books were opened. And another book was opened, which is the Book of Life. And the dead were judged according to their works, by the things which were written in the books. The sea gave up the dead who were in it, and Death and Hades delivered up the dead who were in them. And they were judged, each one according to his works. Then Death and Hades were cast into the lake of fire. This is the second death. And anyone not found written in the Book of Life was cast into the lake of fire.[208]

Two categories exist on the final day: those in the Book of Life and those not. The universalist view believes these two categories still exist, but that the second category will eventually be reconciled to God and join the first category. This passage demonstrates several things against this universalist argument. First, the judgment happens once, without hope of a 're-judgment' later. Hebrews 9:27 reinforces this conclusion saying, "it is appointed for men to die once, but

[208] Rev. 20:12-15.

after this the judgment."[209] Second, the judgment inflicted on those not in the Book of Life is to be 'cast into the lake of fire.' Although universalists may respond that this is symbolic imagery, the reality it represents cannot be far off. Universalism posits the wicked exist in the fire until a time of redemption, but the text simply never indicates this. Finally, death is *also* cast into the lake of fire. This indicates that some classes of things will *not* be reconciled to God, but will be removed.

The words of the Lord in Matthew 25:31-46 also have relevance on the universalism question: "When the Son of Man comes in his glory, and all the angels with him, he will sit on his glorious throne. All the nations will be gathered before him, and he will separate the people one from another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the goats. He will put the sheep on his right and the goats on his left."[210] Jesus then describes the destiny of each. The sheep on his right will receive an "inheritance, the kingdom prepared for you since the creation of the world."[211] The goats on his left will be told: "Depart from me, you who are cursed, into the eternal fire prepared for the devil and his angels."[212] From the previous section on traditionalist proofs, it is clear that the *eternal fire* in question does not produce eternal *torment*, but rather eternal *destruction*. Finally, the wicked on his left "will go away to eternal punishment, but the righteous to eternal life."[213] The punishment is the opposite of eternal life: eternal death. The final decimation of the wicked does not ever end. This fact stands in opposition to the universalist doctrine of temporary death and temporary punishment.

Universalist Thomas Talbott presents several arguments against the conditional immortality position. First he says, "The destruction of something good, namely, those persons

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[209] Heb. 9:27.
[210] Matt. 25:31-33.
[211] Matt. 25:34.
[212] Matt. 25:41.
[213] Matt. 25:46.

who, however sinful, were initially created in the image of God ...in itself, …would leave a terrible stain and blemish on God's creation."[214] Conditionalism agrees that for any person to reject God's free gift of salvation is a devastating tragedy. Nevertheless, God does not redeem the lost. According to His revealed rules of justice, He eliminates wicked people. Proverbs 12:7 states, "The wicked are overthrown and are no more, But the house of the righteous will stand."[215] In this earthly life, God overthrows the unrepentant wicked. In the next life, He will do the same. 1 Corinthians 15:25-26 says, " For He must reign till He has put all enemies under His feet. The last enemy that will be destroyed is death."[216] All God's unrepentant enemies—including death itself—will be made subject to Christ through destruction. God *does* choose to eliminate people or things when they oppose Him. The loss of a human soul is tragic, but not a permanent blemish to God's creation. Rather, the annihilation of hardened, unrepentant wickedness cleanses the future world.

Next, Talbott argues that the Apostle Paul had a universalist conception of final punishment. He states, "That Paul regarded death as a form of eschatological punishment is unquestionably true, but it in no way follows that he therefore had in mind a complete obliteration of consciousness."[217] Talbott then argues that Paul uses the word 'perish' not to indicate the oblivion of death, but rather being 'lost.' Although the point could be argued, it would not matter. Even with the removal of the word 'perish' from the vocabulary of Paul or even the rest of the Bible, adequate evidence still exists to prove conditional immortality.[218] Paul, for example, uses the words death and destruction. He writes in Romans 6:21, "What fruit did you have then in the things of which you are now ashamed? For the end of those things is

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[214] Thomas Talbott, *The Inescapable Love of God* (Eugene, Oregon: Wipf and Stock Publishers), 94.
[215] Prov. 12:7.
[216] 1 Cor. 15:25-26.
[217] Talbott, *Inescapable Love of God*, 95.
[218] Fudge, "The Final End of the Wicked," 41.

death."[219] 1 Corinthians 3:17, "If anyone defiles the temple of God, God will destroy him..."[220] and Philippians 1:28, "For many walk, …[as] enemies of the cross of Christ, whose end is destruction…"[221] In addition, Paul follows Christ's example by emphasizing the finality of God's judgment. 2 Thessalonians 1:9 states, "These shall be punished with everlasting destruction from the presence of the Lord and from the glory of His power."[222] Certainly, therefore, cessation of consciousness is included within Paul's description of final judgment being death and destruction. If it were otherwise, the Scriptures would say so.

Talbott finally suggests that the annihilation spoken of by Paul refers to the annihilation of the 'false self.' In his own words, "Once the consuming fire of God's love has destroyed, whether in this life, in purgatory, or in hell itself, everything that is false within us, once nothing of the false self remains for us to cling to, then nothing of our opposition to God will remain either."[223] Yet the narratives of the Bible discussed earlier seem to claim *much more* than a purification process. The flood wiped out the wicked, their possessions, and even their legacy. Sodom was completely annihilated. Hebrews 12:29 indeed says "our God is a consuming fire,"[224] but this statement comes in the context of repeated warnings not to disobey God to avoid destruction. Hebrews 12:25 says, "See that you do not refuse Him who speaks. For if they did not escape who refused Him who spoke on earth, much more shall we not escape if we turn away from Him who speaks from heaven."[225] Universalists believe everyone will be purified through Hell, but God's purifying is reserved *only* for his children. Hebrews 12:7-8, "If you endure chastening, God deals with you as with sons; for what son is there whom a father does not

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[219] Rom. 6:21.
[220] 1 Cor. 3:17.
[221] Phil. 1:28.
[222] 2 Thess. 1:9.
[223] Talbott, *Inescapable Love of God*, 98.
[224] Heb. 12:29.
[225] Heb. 12:25.

chasten? But if you are without chastening, of which all have become partakers, then you are illegitimate and not sons."

Universalism, while commendable for its pushback on the emotionally intolerable and unbiblical traditional view, does not meet the criteria laid out in God's word. Repeatedly, the Bible emphasizes two categories of people: the saved and unsaved. God's children will receive a purification process through trials and finally gain eternal life. His unrepentant enemies will suffer the vengeance of eternal fire through destruction and be cast into outer darkness, stripping them of their life, consciousness, and existence.

The Impact of Conditional Immortality

The start of this thesis presented an age-old dilemma: how God can be simultaneously just and loving. Hell, as traditionally described, seems to be a contradiction in God's character because it seems neither just *nor* loving. Traditionalists argue it is *just* but fail to convince the unbelieving world that eternal torment represents *love*. Universalism tries to argue that God is *loving*, but fails to account for His *justice*. Conditional immortality fulfills both requirements. God is just because he punishes living sinners with the one thing they deserve: revoked life. There is no gain from sin, only the loss of life that could have been lived indefinitely. In the conditionalist worldview, sin is not an undefeatable virus that forces the sinner to face conscious torment for all time. God ultimately *defeats* sin. This view of Hell comports with God's loving character. Rather than creating two classes of eternal lives, one facing joy the other facing misery, God creates living souls given the opportunity to accept Him and live forever or Reject Him and return to non-existence.

This view is not only more Biblically supported but also proves emotionally superior to the traditional view. Imagine the emotional strain this harsh view has inflicted on sincere Christians over the centuries. How many children have been traumatized by traditional hellfire and brimstone teaching? How many have ended up believing in a false, monstrous version of God? In addition, many Believers have questioned their own happiness in heaven if many of the people they knew on earth continued to suffer for all time. Heaven appears less joyful due to the traditional view of Hell. Many conditionalists argue on this very premise: The Bible describes God as finally victorious over all things; Everything is finally reconciled to him. Is this to be rejected in favor of a God who allows His rebellious enemies to continue hating Him for all eternity?

The annihilation perspective preserves the desire for *missions* and *evangelism* as well, since souls are available to be saved *right now*. The fields remain "white for the harvest"[226] whether the tares are burned up by the fire or tormented in it forever.[227] Dedicated evangelists have been adherents of conditional immortality including John Stott[228]. In fact, there is likely a benefit to evangelism as an annihilationist. Consider a traditionalist apologist who is motivated to preach by the fear of eternal torment. He will attempt to persuade through *fear of an external factor* which he must convince his listener to believe in. Annihilation needs no explanation, as death is naturally feared by all. The conditionalist apologist is therefore closer to practical reality and more persuasive as a result.

Conditional Immortality places the focus for salvation on the unique promise of the Bible that Christians can live forever in a perfect world with no evil or pain. The traditional view incentivizes the unbelieving listener to convert merely to escape the monstrous consequences

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[226] John 4:35.
[227] Matt. 13:24-30; Matt. 13:40.
[228] Date, *Rethinking Hell*, 48-49.

should Hell prove to exist. The dread of eternal torment becomes the chief motivator for salvation rather than the promise of eternal life as presented in Scripture. While certainly not the intent of its adherents, this system inevitably paints God as a vengeful, unreasonable deity who must be obeyed to escape his eternal torture chamber. The Conditional Immortality view presents God as the One who loves all, justifies as many as accept Him, and justly removes those who remain His enemies.

When the eternal conscious torment view is fully applied, the basis for the Christian concept that 'life is a blessing' falls apart. Life becomes value neutral. If every person lives forever in torment or bliss, it cannot be said that life is good. This raises a serious dilemma about whether having children is even morally good. This also taints God's character when considering the immense power rapists have to create eternal souls, many of whom will be tormented for all time—a state of things allowed by God the omnipotent. Within the Conditional Immortality perspective, these questions become far less troublesome. Every created soul has the ability to experience, for a short time, God's goodness as present in this world. Should they accept the offer of salvation, they can experience this goodness for all time. Within the conditionalist view, life is good.

Of course, the ultimate question remains: what does the Bible teach? This thesis has demonstrated that the conditional view is much better supported than the eternal torment view. The traditional perspective rests on several figurative passages that *could* be interpreted to mean eternal torment. When examining the imagery cited in these metaphorical passages, their true meaning becomes evident in that they support annihilation. Conditionalism rests on a wide set of words, phrases, stories, and concepts present from Genesis through Revelation all supporting the final annihilation of the wicked. The metaphorical passages cited for the traditional view should

be interpreted through the much clearer and more abundant texts indicating the wicked will be destroyed. Even if the Biblical support were roughly equal, conditionalism should still be preferred. Occam's razor is a famously used principle in science. It states that a simpler theory should be preferred over a more complex one when both fit the available data. Imagining for a moment that eternal torment and annihilationism were both equally viable theories. Annihilationism would still be better because it is not only considerably more merciful and reasonable, but more simple as well. Traditionalism must introduce foreign concepts about eternal existence in misery while conditional immortality refers to concepts of death that are naturally understood and feared.

Thus, the argument comes to a close. May the reader reflect and ponder these things. Let them critically consider everything claimed, justified, and impacted by all three camps of the debate. In all this, let the reader remember that this issue should not be allowed to divide the church, Christ's body. Yet the question remains vitally important. The final verdict is out; God will enact capital punishment upon his enemies; The wicked will be annihilated.

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